

Photoshop: From First Win to Finished Work

Your working notebook for the whole course — all eight modules. Read the key ideas, study the worked examples, do the exercises in the space provided, and check yourself with the quizzes.

8 modules • 22 lessons

Write-in exercises & self-checks

Name: _____

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Your First Win

Welcome! Before we explain much of anything, you're going to open a photo, make it visibly better, and save a copy you could post or print, in about the length of a coffee break. This is the whole rhythm of Photoshop in miniature.

Lesson 1

1 lesson

Session 1 • 3 hours

Name: _____

HOW TO USE THIS WORKBOOK

Each lesson has **Key Ideas**, a **Worked Example** (the steps you'll follow in class), **Your Turn** exercises (do them in Photoshop, then write what happened), a **Self-Check**, a **Journal** prompt, and space for **Notes**. Photoshop shortcuts are written Windows first, Mac second: **Ct r l / ⌘ + S** means Ctrl+S on Windows, ⌘+S on a Mac.

HOW THIS COURSE WORKS

PROJECT-DRIVEN, NOT A TOOL TOUR

Every module ends in a finished deliverable, and you learn each skill at the moment the project needs it. Eight modules, one per session: **0 First Win** • **1 Foundations** • **2 Light & Color** • **3 Retouching** • **4 Compositing** • **5 Design & Type** • **6 AI & Speed** • **7 Capstone** (a portfolio piece you choose and present).

IT SPIRALS

Four big ideas keep coming back, each time a little deeper: **non-destructive editing**, the **layer stack**, **masks as grayscale**, and **selections**. You don't "finish" them today. You keep meeting them until they're second nature.

THE RECIPES LIBRARY

Short, standalone how-tos ("How do I straighten a crooked horizon?") you can use in any order, each linked to the lesson that teaches the why. Every lesson also ends with a recipe card, reprinted in this workbook. You don't have to memorize everything.

YOUR LEARNING JOURNAL

After every lesson, jot down five things: **key concepts** • **techniques that clicked** • **questions or confusion** • **ideas to try** • **your progress and feelings**. Use the Journal boxes here, a notebook, or a text file.

A WORD BEFORE YOU START

If Photoshop feels like "too much," that feeling is normal, and temporary. You are not going to learn all of Photoshop. Nobody has. You're going to learn the handful of ideas it's built on, and then use them. Add the word **yet** to anything that feels hard today: "I can't straighten a horizon *yet*."

◆ YOUR TURN: WORKSPACE TOUR

With a photo open, find these four neighborhoods and write where each one is on *your* screen: **Tools** · **Options bar** · **Canvas** · **Layers panel**. If panels ever go missing: **Window ► Workspace ► Reset Essentials**.

MODULE PROGRESS TRACKER

- ◆ ☐ I saved a working `.psd` before editing, and saved it again after
- ◆ ☐ My photo is cropped and the horizon looks level
- ◆ ☐ There's a Brightness/Contrast adjustment layer above my photo
- ◆ ☐ Toggling its eyeball turns my edit off and on
- ◆ ☐ I exported a `.jpg` and my original file is untouched
- ◆ ☐ I ran the whole loop a second time, on my own photo, without a demo

◆ BY THE END YOU CAN

- ◆ Open a photo and **straighten & crop** it with the Crop tool
- ◆ Improve its brightness and contrast with a **Brightness/Contrast adjustment layer**
- ◆ Explain, in one sentence, what **non-destructive editing** means and why it matters
- ◆ **Export** a finished JPEG without ever altering your original file

◆ KEY IDEAS

- ◆ **Tracing paper.** Instead of drawing on the photo with a marker, you lay clear sheets over it and make your changes there. Hate a change? Peel that sheet off. The photo underneath is never touched.
- ◆ In Photoshop those sheets are **layers**. Special ones that only carry an instruction ("make everything under me brighter") are **adjustment layers**.
- ◆ **Non-destructive editing** = working so the original is always intact. It's the actual professional workflow, not a beginner shortcut.
- ◆ Four places on screen today: **Tools** (left edge), **Options bar** (along the top), **Canvas** (the big middle), **Layers panel** (bottom-right). Missing the Layers panel? **Window ► Layers** or F7.
- ◆ **Save vs. Export.** Save writes your layered working file (.psd) so you can keep editing. Export flattens everything into one share-ready image (.jpg). Never post the .psd; never edit on the .jpg.

you look down through the sheets



(later) more sheets you can add or remove

● Brightness/Contrast

Your photo (never edited)

what you see = all sheets combined

The non-destructive stack: the photo at the bottom stays pristine.

◆ WORKED EXAMPLE: THE GUIDED BUILD

- 1 **Open & save a working file.** File ► Open your photo. Immediately File ► Save As, format Photoshop (.psd), name it `myphoto-working.psd`. (If asked where, choose **Save on your computer.**)
- 2 **Straighten & crop.** Press C for the Crop tool. Drag a corner inward to remove distracting edges. To straighten, move the cursor just *outside* a corner until it becomes a **bent arrow**, then drag to rotate until the grid lines match the horizon. Press Enter (Return).
- 3 **Add ONE adjustment layer.** At the bottom of the Layers panel click ● ► **Brightness/Contrast**. Nudge Brightness up until the shadows open; nudge Contrast up a little. Toggle the eyeball next to the new layer off and on: the edit vanishes and returns.
- 4 **Save, then export.** File ► Save (Ctrl/⌘ + S). Then File ► Export ► Export As..., format JPG, quality about 80%, and save as `myphoto-final.jpg`.

◆ RECIPE CARD: QUICK FIX & EXPORT (THE 5-STEP LOOP)

- 1 Open → Save As .psd (protect the original)
- 2 C Crop & straighten → Enter
- 3 Layers panel ► ● ► Brightness/Contrast → nudge
- 4 (Optional) ● ► Vibrance → nudge
- 5 File ► Save, then File ► Export ► Export As ► JPG 80%

Golden rule: edits live on adjustment layers, never on the photo.

◆ YOUR TURN 1: THE MAGIC MOMENT

After Step 3, click the eyeball next to your adjustment layer off and on three times. In your own words, what does this prove about your original photo?

◆ YOUR TURN 2: INDEPENDENT PASS ON YOUR OWN PHOTO

Now do the whole loop again, alone, on a photo of your own. The lesson's twist: pick one that's **too bright** (or use `101-too-bright.jpg`). Run the same four steps, but **lower** the brightness a touch. Then click ● again and add a **Vibrance** layer; push Vibrance up gently. Export and compare it with the original. Name your files after your subject (for example `beach-working.psd` and `beach-final.jpg`).

My photo: _____ Layers in my Layers panel, top to bottom:

Going further: drag your two adjustment layers into the opposite order. Did the result change? Describe what you noticed (even "nothing I could see" is a real answer):

◆ SHARE-OUT: ONE CHOICE I MADE

You'll show your before/after by toggling the eyeballs. Finish this sentence to say out loud: "*I _____ because _____.*" (Example: "I lowered brightness because the sky was blown out.")

◆ WATCH OUT

Save As .psd first, every time. It protects your original. **Export with a new name** (`-final.jpg`) so you never overwrite the photo you started with. If the crop box snaps to a fixed shape, click **Clear** in the options bar.

◆ SELF-CHECK

Q1

What does non-destructive editing mean?

- A) Only making small, subtle changes so nothing looks overdone
- B) Making changes on layers above the photo, so the original pixels are never altered
- C) Editing a JPEG copy and deleting it if you don't like it

Q2

Why do you choose File ► Save As and the .psd format right after opening your photo?

- A) A .psd is smaller, so it's faster to share
- B) A .psd remembers your layers so you can change your mind, and your original JPEG stays untouched
- C) Photoshop can't open or edit JPEGs at all

Q3

With the Crop tool active, how do you straighten a tilted horizon?

- A) Move the cursor just outside a corner until it becomes a bent arrow, then drag to rotate until the grid lines match the horizon
- B) Drag a corner handle inward until the horizon looks level
- C) Click and drag inside the crop box to slide the photo

Q4

You click the eyeball next to your Brightness/Contrast layer and the whole effect disappears. What does that tell you?

- A) The adjustment failed and needs to be redone
- B) The photo was permanently brightened and is now being hidden
- C) The edit lives on the adjustment layer, not in the photo itself

Q5

What's the difference between Save and Export?

- A) There's no difference; they're two names for the same command
- B) Save writes your layered .psd so you can keep editing; Export flattens everything into a share-ready .jpg
- C) Save is for Windows and Export is for Mac

Q6

You can't find the Layers panel anywhere on screen. What do you do?

- A) Choose Window ► Layers (or press F7)
- B) Reinstall Photoshop
- C) Close the photo and open it again

Why do you want to learn Photoshop, and what's one image you dream of being able to make? We'll come back to this entry at the Capstone. Also note: key concepts · what clicked · questions · ideas to try · your progress and feelings.

◆ BEFORE THE NEXT LESSON

- ◆ Keep your `.psd`. You'll recognize its layers with new eyes soon.
- ◆ Run the 5-step recipe on two more photos until it feels automatic.

◆ NOTES

YOU FINISHED MODULE 0

The hardest photo you'll ever edit is the first one, and you just did it. Everything from here is a variation on a loop you already know. If it still feels like a cockpit with a thousand switches, that's normal: nobody learns Photoshop by understanding it first. You learn it by finishing things, one photo at a time. In Session 2, Module 1 builds the real mental model behind what you just did: the layer stack and the mask. Bring a landscape with a pale sky, a photo with one clear subject, and a photo with dust or a distracting object.

Foundations

In Module 0 you changed a whole photo. Now you learn to change *only part* of one: read the layer stack, paint a mask, let Photoshop find edges for you, and clean up a photo without destroying a single pixel.

Deliverable: a messy photo, cleaned up and exported.

Lessons 2–4

3 lessons

Session 2 • 3 hours

Name: _____

HOW TO USE THIS WORKBOOK

Each lesson has **Key Ideas**, a **Worked Example** (the steps you'll follow in class), the lesson's **Recipe Card**, **Your Turn** exercises, a **Self-Check**, a **Journal** prompt, and space for **Notes**. Shortcuts are written Windows first, Mac second: **Alt** **t**/**⌘** means Alt on Windows, Option on a Mac.

WHEN "IT'S NOT DOING ANYTHING," ASK THREE QUESTIONS

1. **Which layer is highlighted?** 2. **Which thumbnail has the border** (the image or the mask)? 3. **What does the options bar say** (Sample All Layers? Sample: Current & Below?)? Nearly every stuck moment in this module is one of these three.

MODULE PROGRESS TRACKER

- ◆ ☐ **L02** I darkened only the sky with a masked adjustment layer (`sky-rescue-final.jpg`)
- ◆ ☐ **L03** I cut out a subject with a layer mask, not the Eraser, and put it on a calmer background
- ◆ ☐ **L04** I cleaned up a photo on a separate `retouch` layer and exported `cleanup-final.jpg`
- ◆ ☐ I wrote a journal entry after each lesson

◆ BY THE END YOU CAN

- ◆ Read a layer stack: what's on top wins, and why order matters
- ◆ Explain a mask in one sentence: **black hides, white reveals, gray partly reveals**
- ◆ Paint on a layer mask to apply an adjustment to only part of a photo
- ◆ Recover from mistakes by painting the mask back: no undo panic required

◆ KEY IDEAS

- ◆ **The stack of glass.** Layers are sheets of glass in a frame; you look straight down. **Higher layers win where they're opaque. Order is meaning:** move a sheet and the picture changes.
- ◆ Every adjustment layer comes with a **layer mask**: a grayscale card that decides, pixel by pixel, how much of the effect gets through.
- ◆ **Black hides. White reveals. Gray does a bit of both.**
- ◆ An adjustment layer shows **two thumbnails**: the effect (🎨) and the mask (the white/black card). Click the **mask** thumbnail before you paint.
- ◆ Masks make mistakes painless: press X to swap brush color and paint the mistake back. That's why pros mask instead of erase.



the mask

- white: effect shows (sky)
- gray: partial, soft seam
- black: effect hidden (land)

Black hides, white reveals, gray blends.

◆ WORKED EXAMPLE: RESCUE THE SKY

- 1 Open a landscape (or `l02-washed-sky.jpg`). File ► Save As ► `sky-rescue-working.psd`.

- 2 Layers panel ►  ► **Brightness/Contrast**. Pull Brightness **down** until the sky looks rich. Ignore the land going dark.
- 3 Click the **mask thumbnail**. Press D, then X so black is the foreground. **Edit** ► **Fill...** ► Contents: **Black**, or **Alt/⌘ + Backspace/Delete**. The darkening vanishes.
- 4 Press B for the Brush, X for white, pick a big soft brush, and paint over the sky. The darkening comes back only where you paint.
- 5 At the horizon, lower brush opacity to about **30%** and blend gently. Toggle the eyeball for the before/after. **File** ► **Save**, then **File** ► **Export** ► **Export As** ► **JPG 80%** → `sky-rescue-final.jpg`.

◆ **RECIPE CARD: MASK AN ADJUSTMENT TO "ONLY HERE"**

- 1 Add adjustment layer () → push it too far on purpose
- 2 Click the mask thumbnail
- 3 Fill black (hide it everywhere): **Alt/⌘ + Backspace** with black foreground
- 4 Brush white (B, soft, big) over the area you want the effect
- 5 Mistakes → press X to swap to black, paint them out

Mantra: black hides, white reveals, gray blends.

◆ **YOUR TURN 1: WATCH THE STENCIL GROW**

While you paint the sky in, watch the mask thumbnail. Sketch what your finished mask looks like (shade the black areas):

◆ **YOUR TURN 2: SPOTLIGHT A SUBJECT**

On a portrait or object photo (or `102-spotlight-object.jpg`): add a Brightness/Contrast layer and **brighten**. Fill the mask black, then paint white only over the face or object: a gentle spotlight. Then add a second adjustment layer that **darkens**, masked so it only touches the background. What did the second layer do to how the subject stands out?

Going further: select a mask thumbnail and press **Ctrl/⌘ + I** to invert it. What happened?

◆ WATCH OUT

Use **Alt/⌘ + Backspace** to fill black, **not Ctrl/⌘ + Backspace** (that fills with the background color). Hard, obvious edge? Right-click the canvas, lower **Hardness**, and paint the seam at low opacity.

◆ SELF-CHECK

Q1

In the stack-of-glass model, what happens where a higher layer is opaque?

- A) It blends evenly with the layer below
- B) It covers what's below it
- C) It disappears behind the layers below

Q2

You paint black on an adjustment layer's mask. What happens in that area?

- A) The adjustment is hidden there, and the original shows through
- B) The photo turns black there
- C) The adjustment gets twice as strong there

Q3

You selected the mask, pressed **Ctrl/⌘ + Backspace** to fill it black, and nothing changed. Why?

- A) Adjustment-layer masks can't be filled
- B) You needed to be zoomed to 100% first
- C) That shortcut fills with the background color, which was white

Q4

While painting white to reveal the sky, you painted over part of the land by mistake. What's the best fix?

- A) Delete the adjustment layer and start over
- B) Press X to switch to black and paint over the mistake
- C) Use the Eraser on the photo layer

Q5

An adjustment layer shows two thumbnails. Which should you click before painting, as a habit?

- A) The mask thumbnail (the white/black card)
- B) The effect thumbnail (the half-moon )
- C) The photo layer underneath

Q6

Your masked edit has a hard, obvious line at the horizon. What went wrong, and how do you fix it?

- A) The adjustment is too strong; lower Brightness
- B) The mask is inverted; press Ctrl/⌘ + I
- C) The brush was too hard; lower Hardness and paint the seam at low opacity

◆ JOURNAL

Describe, in your own words and without looking, what happens when you paint black on a mask versus white. If you can teach it to an imaginary friend, you own it. Also note: key concepts · what clicked · questions · ideas to try · your progress and feelings.

IF MASKS FEEL WEIRD RIGHT NOW

That's not a sign you're behind. It's the sign you just met the idea everyone wrestles with once and then never forgets. Give it one more photo. When it clicks, half of Photoshop opens up at once.

◆ NOTES

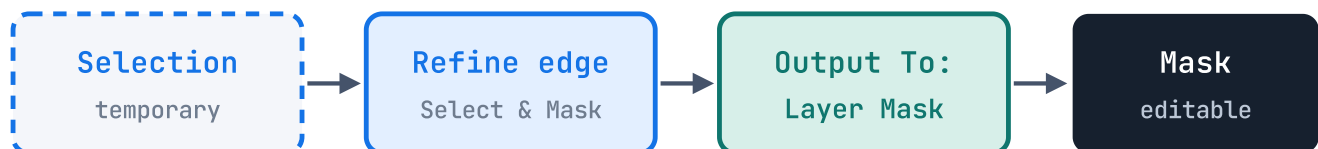
◆ BY THE END YOU CAN

- ◆ Explain the difference between a **selection** (a temporary request) and a **mask** (the saved answer)
- ◆ Select a subject automatically with **Select Subject** and the **Object Selection** tool
- ◆ Rescue tricky edges (hair, fur, motion) in the **Select & Mask** workspace
- ◆ Output a selection to a **layer mask** so your cutout stays non-destructive and re-editable

◆ KEY IDEAS

- ◆ A selection shows **marching ants**. It's temporary: you pointing and saying "these pixels, please." Click elsewhere and it's gone.
- ◆ A **mask** is the request written down permanently: inside the ants becomes white (revealed), outside becomes black (hidden).
- ◆ Pros make a good-enough selection, turn it into a mask, and refine the mask forever after. **Mask it, don't erase it.**

TOOL	BEST FOR	HOW IT THINKS
Select Subject	A clear main subject on any background	AI guesses the whole subject instantly: your best first click
Object Selection	One object among several	Draw a loose box; it snaps to the object inside
Quick Selection	Fixing or extending a selection by hand	Paint and it grows to matching edges
Select & Mask	Hair, fur, soft or motion edges	A whole room for refining the edge of any selection



Select, refine, and save the answer as a mask rather than erasing.

◆ WORKED EXAMPLE: CUT OUT A SUBJECT

- 1 Open a photo with one clear subject (or `103-subject-busy-bg.jpg`). **Save As** `cutout-working.psd`.
- 2 **Select ► Subject**. Marching ants appear. Not perfect? Expected and fine.
- 3 Quick Selection (W; Shift + W cycles the slot): paint to add missed subject; hold Alt/⌘ and paint to subtract background.
- 4 **Select and Mask...** in the options bar. View: **Overlay**. **Refine Edge Brush** along wispy edges. Nudge **Smooth** and **Feather**; **Shift Edge** slightly negative. Colored fringe? Check **Decontaminate Colors**.
- 5 **Output To: Layer Mask → OK**. Add a layer beneath (Ctrl/⌘-click the New Layer icon), fill it with a calm color or place another photo there. **File ► Save**.

◆ RECIPE CARD: SELECT → MASK

- 1 Select ► Subject (let AI start)
- 2 Quick Selection (W): paint to add, Alt/⌘-paint to subtract
- 3 Select and Mask... → Refine Edge Brush on hair; nudge Smooth / Feather / Shift Edge (Decontaminate Colors for fringes)
- 4 Output To: Layer Mask → OK
- 5 New background layer beneath; paint the mask to fix strays; File ► Save

Mantra: mask it, don't erase it.

◆ YOUR TURN 1: FIX A STRAY, THEN FLIP THE MASK OFF

After your cutout, click the mask and paint one stray pixel away (black hides, white reveals). Then Shift-click the mask thumbnail to turn the mask off and on. What does this tell you about what happened to the background?

◆ YOUR TURN 2: A HARDER SUBJECT

Cut out something with wispy hair, fur, or leaves (or `103-fuzzy-subject.jpg`). Lean on the Refine Edge Brush for the wispy parts. Place it on a photo of a different scene (or `103-other-scene.jpg`). Do the colors clash? Note what you see (matching light is what Module 4 is about):

Going further: select your subject, then **Select ► Inverse** (Ctrl/⌘ + Shift + I). What's selected now?

◆ WATCH OUT

Never press **Delete** on a selection to remove a background: that destroys pixels. Always set **Output To: Layer Mask**. If Decontaminate Colors "hid" your original layer, it's still there: look for its eyeball.

◆ SELF-CHECK

Q1

What's the difference between a selection and a mask?

- A) They're the same thing with different names
- B) A selection is permanent; a mask disappears when you click elsewhere
- C) A selection is a temporary request; a mask is the saved, editable answer

Q2

On a busy photo, Select Subject grabbed the wrong thing. What should you try?

- A) Run Select Subject again until it changes its mind
- B) Use the Object Selection tool and draw a box around exactly the thing you want
- C) Trace the subject with the Eraser

Q3

With the Quick Selection tool, how do you subtract background that got included?

- A) Hold Alt/⌘ while you paint over it
- B) Hold Shift while you paint over it
- C) Press Delete

Q4

Your subject's hair edges look chunky. Which tool rebuilds fine strands?

- A) A normal Brush on the mask, painting each strand
- B) The Magic Wand
- C) The Refine Edge Brush in Select & Mask, painted along the hairline

Q5

In Select & Mask, which Output To setting keeps your cutout non-destructive in this lesson's build?

- A) Selection, then press Delete
- B) Layer Mask
- C) New Document

Q6

Your cutout has a bright halo and a colored fringe from the old background. What helps?

- A) Shift Edge slightly negative, plus Decontaminate Colors
- B) Raise Contrast in a Brightness/Contrast layer
- C) Make the edge razor-sharp with Smooth and Feather at zero

◆ JOURNAL

Which was harder: making the selection, or making the edge believable? That answer tells you where to point your practice next. Also note: key concepts · what clicked · questions · ideas to try · your progress and feelings.

YOU JUST LEARNED A MARKETABLE SKILL

Selections used to be the thing that made people quit Photoshop. You met the modern, AI-assisted version and turned it into a non-destructive mask on your first try. If your edges aren't perfect yet, that's what practice is for: two more cutouts of increasing difficulty and Select & Mask will feel familiar.

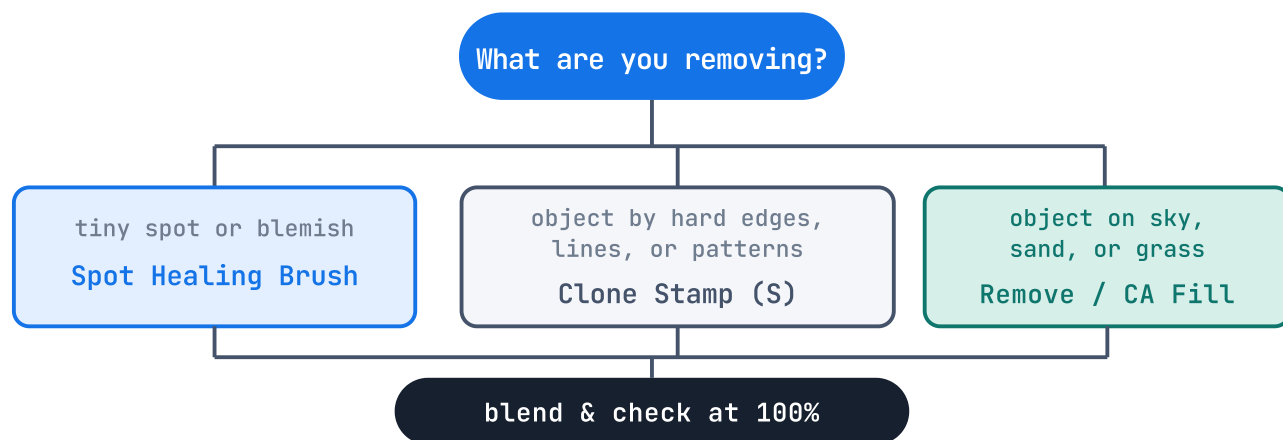
◆ NOTES

◆ BY THE END YOU CAN

- ◆ Remove small spots and blemishes with the **Spot Healing Brush**
- ◆ Choose between **healing** (blends texture) and **cloning** (copies exactly), and know when each wins
- ◆ Erase a larger distraction with **Content-Aware Fill** or the **Remove tool**
- ◆ Work non-destructively by healing on a **separate layer**, then export your finished image

◆ KEY IDEAS

- ◆ Every cleanup tool **borrow good pixels to cover bad ones**. They differ only in how they blend.
- ◆ **Cloning** copies exactly: great for hard edges and patterns, ruthless if the lighting doesn't match.
- ◆ **Healing** copies texture, then blends color and brightness into the surroundings: magic on skin and skies.
- ◆ **Content-Aware** tools do it automatically over a whole region.
- ◆ **The habit**: clean up on an empty layer, with every tool sampling all layers: the **Sample All Layers** checkbox (Spot Healing Brush, Remove tool) or the **Sample**: menu set to **Current & Below** or **All Layers** (Healing Brush, Clone Stamp).



When in doubt, try the Remove tool first: it's the most forgiving.

◆ WORKED EXAMPLE: CLEAN & EXPORT

- 1 Open your messy photo (or `L04-dusty-sky.jpg`). Save As `cleanup-working.psd`. Click the **New Layer** icon; name it `retouch`.
- 2 **Spot Healing Brush** (J), check **Sample All Layers**. Zoom to 100% (Ctrl/⌘ + 1). Brush just a little larger than each spot; single-click it. Work left to right, top to bottom.

- 3 **Big distraction, Option A:** Remove tool (healing group), Sample All Layers checked, brush over the whole object, release. **Option B:** click the **photo** layer, Lasso (L) a loose selection with margin, **Edit ► Content-Aware Fill...**, green-brush the areas to sample from, **Output To: New Layer**, OK. Then click **retouch** again.
- 4 **Stubborn hard edge:** Clone Stamp (S), **Sample: Current & Below**. **Alt/⌘**-click a clean area, then paint over the flaw.
- 5 Final 100% pass. **File ► Save**, then **File ► Export ► Export As ► JPG 80% → cleanup-final.jpg**.

◆ RECIPE CARD: CLEAN A PHOTO (DISTRACTION-FREE IN FIVE MOVES)

- 1 New empty layer named **retouch** → every tool samples all layers (checkbox or Sample: menu)
- 2 Spot Healing Brush (J): click each tiny spot at 100% zoom
- 3 Big object → Remove tool (brush over) or Edit ► Content-Aware Fill
- 4 Stubborn edge → Clone Stamp (S, Sample: Current & Below, **Alt/⌘**-sample)
- 5 100% final pass → Save .psd → Export JPG

Mantra: heal to blend, clone to copy, always on a fresh layer.

◆ YOUR TURN 1: PROVE IT'S NON-DESTRUCTIVE

After your spot pass, toggle the **retouch** layer's eyeball. What comes back? How many spots did you remove?

◆ YOUR TURN 2: TWO WAYS, ONE DISTRACTION

On a photo with a photobomber, trash can, or power line (or **104-photobomb.jpg**), remove it **twice**: once with the Remove tool, once with Content-Aware Fill. Zoom to 100% and hunt for smears, repeats, and halos; fix them with the Clone Stamp.

	REMOVE TOOL	CONTENT-AWARE FILL
What it did well		
Tell-tale signs I found		
Winner for this photo		

◆ WATCH OUT

Nothing happens on your empty layer? Check **Sample All Layers**. Clone Stamp paints nothing? Its **Sample:** menu is a separate setting: set it to **Current & Below**, and **Alt** + **⌘**-click a source first.

◆ SELF - CHECK

Q1

What's the difference between healing and cloning?

- A) Healing is only for skin; cloning is only for skies
- B) Healing blends the borrowed texture's color and brightness into its surroundings; cloning copies pixels exactly
- C) Cloning is automatic; healing needs a selection

Q2

Why do all your cleanup on a separate, empty **retouch** layer?

- A) The healing tools only work on empty layers
- B) It makes the exported JPEG smaller
- C) The original photo is never touched, and a bad heal can simply be erased off that layer

Q3

You click a dust spot with the Spot Healing Brush on your empty **retouch** layer, and nothing happens. What's the likely cause?

- A) Sample All Layers is unchecked in the options bar
- B) You're zoomed to 100%
- C) The brush is a little larger than the spot

Q4

A pole stands right against a building's straight, hard roofline. Following the decision tree, which tool is best for the part along that edge?

- A) Spot Healing Brush
- B) Content-Aware Fill with a huge selection
- C) Clone Stamp

Q5

On your **retouch** layer, the Clone Stamp paints nothing at all. What do you do?

- A) Check Sample All Layers on the Spot Healing Brush
- B) Set the Clone Stamp's Sample: menu to Current & Below, then Alt/⌘-click a clean source
- C) Switch to the photo layer and clone there

Q6

How do you know a photo is "clean enough"?

- A) One pass at 100% zoom, then view it fit-to-screen: if nothing pulls your eye from the subject, you're done
- B) When it looks perfect at 400% zoom
- C) After you've used every cleanup tool at least once

◆ JOURNAL

Look back at your Module 0 journal entry: the image you dreamed of making. After finishing Module 1, which specific skill from these three lessons gets you closest to it? Also note: key concepts · what clicked · questions · ideas to try · your progress and feelings.

◆ BEFORE THE NEXT MODULE

- ◆ Run the full Module 1 workflow on one fresh photo end to end: mask an adjustment, cut out the subject, clean the frame, export.
- ◆ Save your best result. You'll re-grade it in Module 2.

◆ NOTES

YOU FINISHED MODULE 1

Look at the arc: you can read a layer stack, target an edit with a mask, make a believable selection and bake it into a mask, and clean up a photo without destroying a pixel. That's not beginner luck; that's a method you now own, and it's the foundation for everything ahead. In Module 2 (Light & Color) things start to get genuinely beautiful: Camera Raw, Curves, and Smart Objects.

Light & Color

Module 1 got your photo clean and under control. Module 2 makes it beautiful. You'll develop a photo in Camera Raw, shape its light and color with Curves, and keep every single decision re-editable inside a Smart Object. One file carries you through all three lessons, so save often.

Lessons 5-7

3 lessons

Session 3 • 3 hrs

Name: _____

HOW TO USE THIS WORKBOOK

Each lesson has **By the end you can** goals, **Key Ideas**, a **Worked Example** to follow on your own computer, **Your Turn** exercises to write in, a **Self-Check** quiz, a **Journal** prompt, and space for **Notes**. Judge color on *your own screen*, not the projector: projectors shift color. If something looks wrong, that's information, not failure.

MODULE PROGRESS TRACKER

- ◆ ☐ **L05:** My photo is a Smart Object, developed in a re-editable Camera Raw Smart Filter, saved as `grade-working.psd`
- ◆ ☐ **L06:** I added an S-curve, graded a color channel, and masked a second Curves layer to one region
- ◆ ☐ **L07:** I added a masked Smart Filter, passed the scale test, and exported `module2-grade-final.jpg`

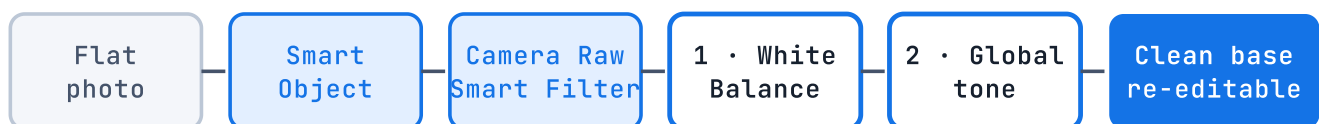
◆ BY THE END YOU CAN

- ◆ Open a photo as a **Smart Object** so Camera Raw becomes a re-editable **Smart Filter**
- ◆ Fix a color cast with **White Balance** (Temperature and Tint)
- ◆ Set global tone with **Exposure, Contrast, Highlights, Shadows, Whites and Blacks**
- ◆ Explain why you develop *globally first*, before any local edits

◆ KEY IDEAS

- ◆ Camera Raw is the **develop step**: the digital darkroom where you get the raw light honest before any creative choice.
- ◆ **Global before local**. Fix the whole image (white balance, overall tone) first. Dodging and burning a photo that still has an orange cast is just polishing a problem.
- ◆ Convert the layer to a **Smart Object** first. Then Camera Raw attaches as a **Smart Filter** you can double-click and re-edit forever.
- ◆ Work the panel **top to bottom**: White Balance, then Exposure → Contrast → Highlights/Shadows → Whites/Blacks.
- ◆ **Clipping** means a highlight has gone pure white (or a shadow pure black) with no detail left. Hold **Alt** / **⌥** while dragging Whites or Blacks to see exactly where it happens.

the develop order



White balance first, then tone, and it stays re-editable because it's a Smart Filter.

◆ WORKED EXAMPLE: THE DEVELOP PASS

- 1 **File ▶ Open** your photo, then **File ▶ Save As** → `grade-working.psd`.
- 2 Right-click the layer **on its name** (not the thumbnail) ▶ **Convert to Smart Object**. Look for the page badge on the thumbnail.
- 3 **Filter ▶ Camera Raw Filter...** (**Shift + Ctrl + A** / **⌘ + ⌘ + A**).
- 4 **White Balance eyedropper**: click something that should be neutral gray or white. Fine-tune **Temperature** and **Tint**. Look away, then look back.

- 5 **Exposure** first, a gentle **Contrast** nudge, **Highlights** down, **Shadows** up.
- 6 Hold **Alt** / **⌘**: drag **Whites** until just shy of clipping, **Blacks** down until you have a true black.
- 7 **OK**. Toggle the Smart Filter's  for before/after. **File ▶ Save** (**Ctrl**/**⌘** + **S**).

Your screen may group the sliders a little differently from this list (section names vary between Camera Raw versions). Follow the **order**, wherever the sliders sit.

◆ YOUR TURN: MATCH THE PROBLEM TO THE SLIDER

Write the slider (or tool) you'd reach for first:

THE PROBLEM	I'D REACH FOR...
Whites look orange under indoor lights	_____
The whole photo is too dark	_____
The sky is blown out, almost white	_____
The shadows are muddy; I can't see detail	_____
The image looks flat and hazy	_____
There's no true black anywhere	_____

◆ YOUR TURN: DEVELOP A FLAT PHOTO

Use `105-flat-cast.jpg` or your own flat or indoor photo. Record what you did:

- ◆ ☐ Smart Object badge on the thumbnail
- ◆ ☐ Whites look neutral (no orange or blue cast)
- ◆ ☐ A true black and a clean white somewhere in the image
- ◆ ☐ Highlights and shadows both show detail
- ◆ ☐ Camera Raw is a re-editable Smart Filter
- ◆ ☐ Saved `grade-working.psd`

The neutral object I clicked with the eyedropper, and the sliders I moved most:

◆ SELF-CHECK

Q1

Why convert the layer to a Smart Object before choosing Filter ► Camera Raw Filter?

- A) Camera Raw refuses to open on a normal layer
- B) So Camera Raw is applied as a re-editable Smart Filter you can reopen and change any time
- C) So the file gets smaller

Q2

An indoor photo has orange-looking whites. What's the fastest first move in Camera Raw?

- A) Click the White Balance eyedropper on something that should be neutral gray or white
- B) Drag Exposure down
- C) Push Contrast up

Q3

Which order does the develop pass follow?

- A) Whites/Blacks → Exposure → White Balance
- B) Contrast → White Balance → Shadows → Exposure
- C) White Balance → Exposure → Contrast → Highlights/Shadows → Whites/Blacks

Q4

What does holding **Alt / **⌥** while dragging the Whites or Blacks slider show you?**

- A) Where the image is clipping: pure white or pure black with no detail left
- B) A side-by-side before and after
- C) The original, undeveloped photo

Q5

What does "global before local" mean?

- A) Always edit the background before the subject
- B) Fix the whole image first (white balance, overall tone), then make selective local tweaks
- C) Apply filters before adjustment layers

Q6

You only have a JPEG, not a RAW file. Can you still do the develop step?

- A) No, Camera Raw only opens RAW files
- B) Only after converting the JPEG to RAW
- C) Yes, the Camera Raw Filter runs on any layer; RAW just gives more room to recover highlights and shadows

◆ JOURNAL

Which mattered more for your photo: fixing the color cast, or setting the tone? Grading is personal; noticing your own instinct is the start of a style. Also note: key concepts · what clicked · questions · ideas to try · how you feel about your progress.

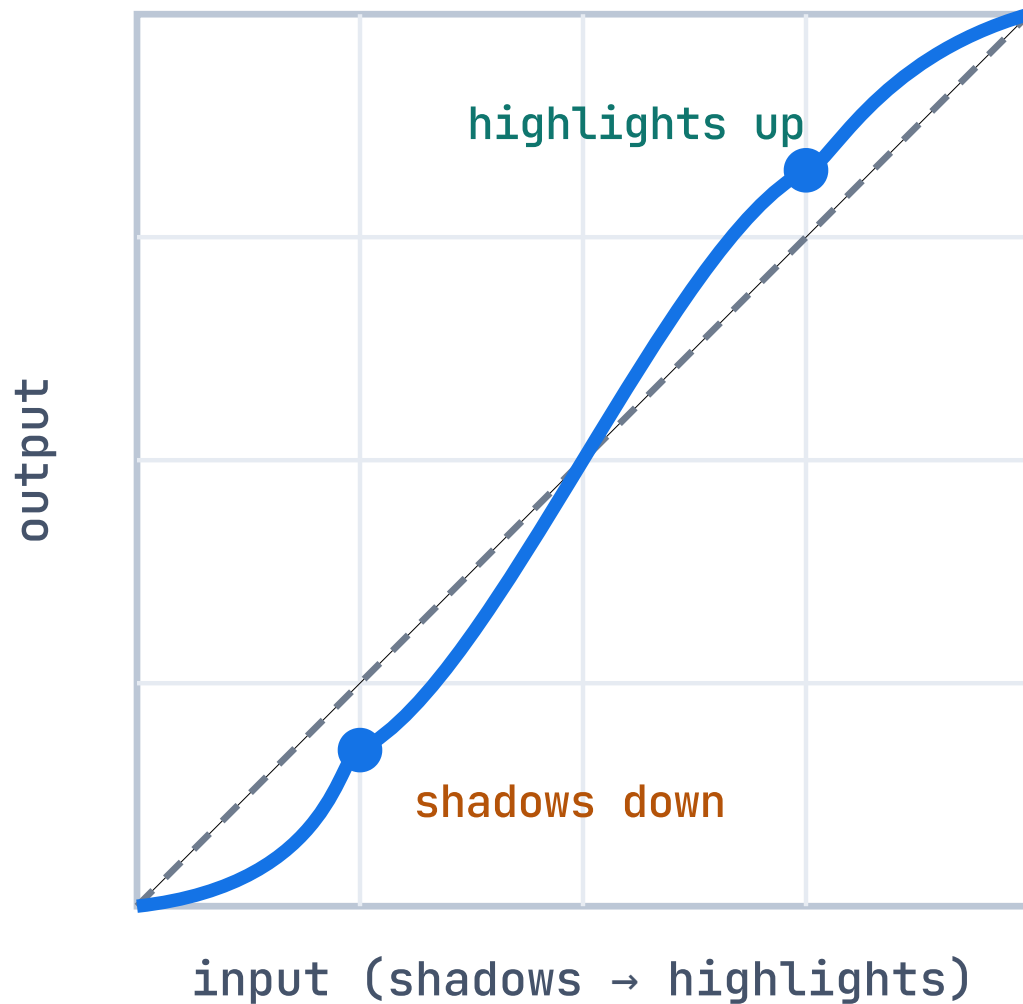
◆ NOTES

◆ BY THE END YOU CAN

- ◆ Read the Curves graph: input across, output up, the diagonal is "no change"
- ◆ Add contrast with an **S-curve**, and flatten it for a soft, filmic look
- ◆ Color-grade by bending the **Red, Green and Blue** channels
- ◆ Apply a Curves adjustment layer to only part of the photo with a **mask**

◆ KEY IDEAS

- ◆ A curve is a **tone translator**. Tones walk in along the bottom (input) and out up the side (output). The straight diagonal means "leave it alone."
- ◆ Bend a point **up** and those tones get brighter; bend it **down** and they get darker. You choose which tones: shadows, midtones, or highlights.
- ◆ **S-curve** = shadows down, highlights up = more contrast. **Lifted bottom-left corner** = milky, faded blacks (matte, vintage).
- ◆ **Channel curves** grade color. In the Blue channel, shadows up + highlights down = cool shadows, warm highlights. Add Red shadows down for a truer teal. Move in tiny amounts.
- ◆ A **masked** Curves layer grades one region only: fill the mask black, paint white where you want the effect.
- ◆ Curves layers go **above** your Camera Raw develop. Global first, again.



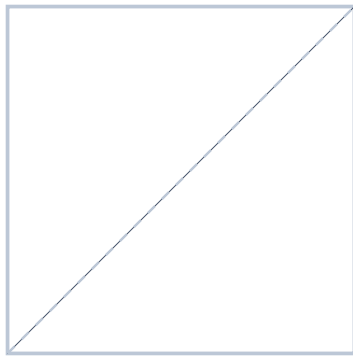
Dashed diagonal = no change. Blue S-curve = more contrast.

◆ WORKED EXAMPLE: CONTRAST & COLOR

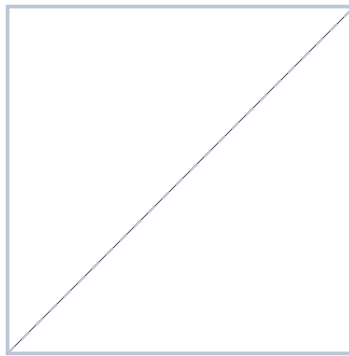
- 1 Open `grade-working.psd` from L05. Click ● at the bottom of the Layers panel ► **Curves**.
- 2 Click a point about a quarter of the way up the line and drag it gently **down**. Click about three quarters up and drag gently **up**. That's your S.
- 3 Change the channel menu from **RGB** to **Blue**: lift the shadow end slightly, drop the highlight end slightly. For truer teal, switch to **Red** and pull its shadow end down slightly.
- 4 Add a **second** Curves layer and brighten it noticeably.
- 5 Click its **mask thumbnail**. Press D, then X so black is the foreground, then **Alt + Backspace** / **⌘ + Delete** to fill the mask black (or press **Ctrl/⌘ + I** to invert the white mask).
- 6 Press X for white; paint over your subject with a soft brush (B). **File ► Save**.

◆ YOUR TURN: SKETCH THE CURVE

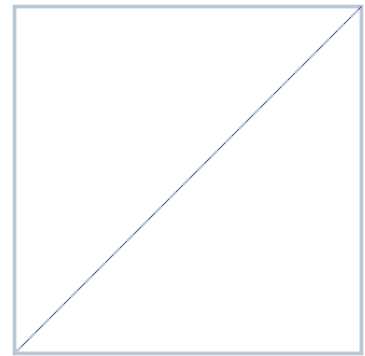
Draw the curve you'd use for each look. The dashed line is "no change."



1 • brighter overall



2 • more contrast



3 • faded, matte blacks

◆ YOUR TURN: GRADE ONE REGION

Which region did you grade with your masked Curves layer (subject, sky, foreground)? What did the masked layer do to it, and why did you choose that region?

◆ WATCH OUT

Colors went wild? You moved a channel too far: a few pixels of drag on Blue is already a strong grade. **Paint showing up as white smears on the photo?** You had the image selected, not the mask. Undo and click the mask thumbnail first. **Skin blotchy or sky banded?** Your S-curve is too strong for that area; soften it or mask it.

◆ SELF-CHECK

Q1

On an untouched Curves graph, what does the straight diagonal line mean?

A) Every tone leaves exactly as it came in: no change

B) The image is clipped

C) Contrast is at its maximum

Q2

A photo looks flat and hazy. Which curve adds contrast?

- A) One point pulled up in the middle
- B) The bottom-left corner lifted up
- C) An S-curve: the shadows point dragged down, the highlights point dragged up

Q3

What does lifting the bottom-left corner (the black end) of the curve do?

- A) Makes blacks deeper and richer
- B) Gives "milky," faded blacks for a matte or vintage look
- C) Warms the whole image

Q4

In the Blue channel you lift the shadow end slightly and drop the highlight end slightly. What's the result?

- A) Cool (blue) shadows and warm (yellow) highlights
- B) Warm shadows and cool highlights
- C) A black-and-white image

Q5

You added a Curves layer that brightens the photo, but you want it to affect only your subject. What next?

- A) Lower the Curves layer's opacity to 50%
- B) Fill its mask black, then paint white over the subject with a soft brush
- C) Paint black directly on the photo layer around the subject

Q6

Where should your Curves adjustment layers sit relative to the Camera Raw develop?

- A) Below it, so Camera Raw can correct them
- B) It doesn't matter; the result is identical
- C) Above it: develop globally first, then stack Curves on top

◆ JOURNAL

Did Curves feel like math or like a dimmer switch by the end? Describe the S-curve to yourself in one plain sentence: that sentence is proof it clicked. Also note: key concepts · what clicked · questions · ideas to try · how you feel about your progress.

ADD THE WORD "YET"

Curves intimidates more beginners than any other tool. If it doesn't feel natural, it doesn't feel natural yet. Five S-curves on five photos and the shape becomes muscle memory.

◆ NOTES

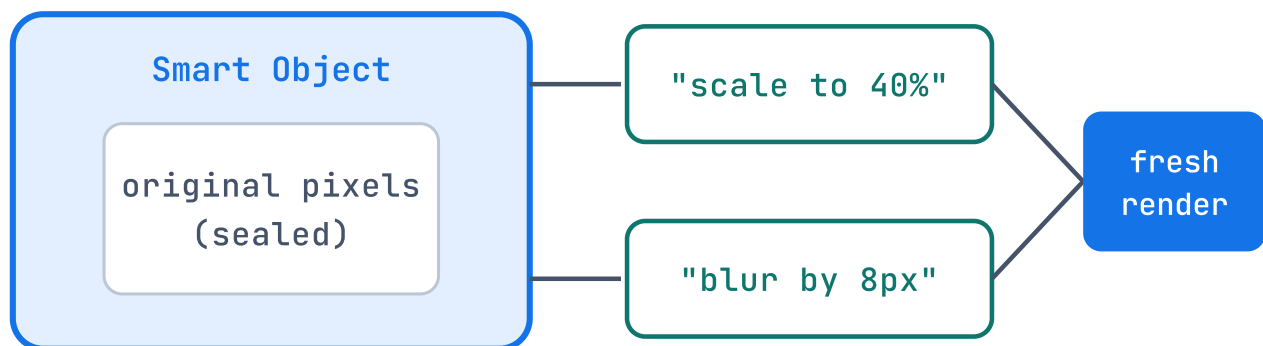
◆ BY THE END YOU CAN

- ◆ Explain what a **Smart Object** is: a protective container around your pixels
- ◆ Scale, warp, and transform without losing quality
- ◆ Apply **Smart Filters** that stay re-editable and maskable
- ◆ Finish a fully non-destructive grade and export it

◆ KEY IDEAS

- ◆ A **Smart Object** stores your pixels; everything you do to it is a re-editable instruction, not a permanent change.
- ◆ Scale a **normal layer** down and back up and it turns to mush: the pixels were thrown away. A **Smart Object** re-renders crisp from the sealed original.
- ◆ Any filter on a Smart Object nests beneath it as a **Smart Filter**. Filters share one **filter mask**, the newest sits on top, and they apply from the bottom up.
- ◆ Paint the filter mask black to hide the filter in an area (black hides, white reveals).
- ◆ Don't heal or clone directly on a Smart Object: those tools want normal pixels. Retouch first, then convert.
- ◆ Keep the layered `.psd` as your **master**; export a flat JPEG as the deliverable.

edits are instructions on the outside of the box



The pixels inside never degrade; change an instruction and it re-renders.

◆ WORKED EXAMPLE: FINISH THE GRADE

- 1 Open `grade-working.psd`. Check the photo layer's thumbnail for the page-fold badge (if missing: right-click ► **Convert to Smart Object**).
- 2 With the Smart Object selected: **Filter ► Sharpen ► Smart Sharpen** (crisp detail) or **Filter ► Blur ► Gaussian Blur** (a dreamy glow).
- 3 For a glow: double-click the small **Blending Options** icon at the right end of the Gaussian Blur row, set **Mode: Soft Light** (or Screen), **Opacity** about 20–40%.
- 4 Click the white **Smart Filters** mask and paint black where you don't want the filter.
- 5 **Ctrl/⌘ + T**: scale to 30%, commit; scale back to 100%, commit. Still crisp? (If Photoshop warns that Smart Filters are off while transforming, click OK.)
- 6 **File ► Save the** `.psd`. Then **File ► Export ► Export As ► JPG 80% →** `module2-grade-final.jpg`.

◆ YOUR TURN: CRISP OR MUSHY?

Open `107-badge-crisp.png`. Duplicate the layer, convert *one* copy to a Smart Object, then scale both to 30% and back to 100%. Zoom to 100% (**Ctrl/⌘ + 1**). Describe what happened to the thin lines and small text on each copy:

◆ YOUR TURN: IN YOUR OWN WORDS

Explain a Smart Object to a friend who has never used Photoshop, in two sentences or fewer:

◆ SELF-CHECK

Q1

Which is the best one-line definition of a Smart Object?

A) A layer that automatically enhances your photo

B) A compressed layer that makes files smaller

C) A container that stores your original pixels; every edit is a re-editable instruction

Q2

You scale a layer to 30% and back to 100%. The normal layer turns mushy but the Smart Object stays crisp. Why?

- A) Smart Objects are automatically sharpened
- B) The Smart Object re-renders from its sealed original pixels
- C) Normal layers can't be scaled back up at all

Q3

You applied Smart Sharpen as a Smart Filter and want it on the eyes but not the skin. How?

- A) Paint black on the Smart Filters mask over the skin
- B) Delete the filter and sharpen with a brush
- C) Lower the whole layer's opacity

Q4

You want a Gaussian Blur Smart Filter to look like a soft glow, not a blurry photo. What do you change?

- A) Increase the blur radius
- B) Convert the Smart Object back to a normal layer
- C) Double-click the filter's Blending Options icon; set Mode to Soft Light (or Screen) at about 20–40% opacity

Q5

When should you *not* work on a Smart Object?

- A) When scaling or warping
- B) When healing or cloning directly on the layer's pixels
- C) When applying Camera Raw

Q6

You exported `module2-grade-final.jpg`. Why keep the layered `.psd` too?

- A) The PSD is your re-editable master; the JPEG is flat and can't be re-graded
- B) You need the PSD to open the JPEG
- C) You don't; delete it to save space

◆ JOURNAL

Non-destructive editing has now shown up in every module: layers, masks, adjustment layers, Smart Objects. In your own words, why do professionals care so much about never committing an edit? Also note: key concepts · what clicked · questions · ideas to try · how you feel about your progress.

◆ NOTES

YOU FINISHED MODULE 2 🎉

You can take a flat, wrongly colored photo and make it genuinely beautiful: develop it, shape its light and color, grade a region with a mask, and keep the whole thing re-editable. That's a real colorist's workflow. Before Session 4: grade one more photo start to finish, and bring a portrait (a self-portrait, or someone who has agreed to be edited and shown in class).

Retouching

Welcome to the Practitioner tier. Module 3 is about people, and the golden rule of portrait work is that great retouching is invisible: your subject should look like themselves on their best day. You'll heal the temporary, even out skin tone without losing texture, and sculpt the face with light, all on one portrait file.

Lessons 8–10

3 lessons

Session 4 • 3 hrs

Name: _____

HOW TO USE THIS WORKBOOK

Each lesson has goals, **Key Ideas**, a **Worked Example**, **Your Turn** exercises, a **Self-Check**, a **Journal** prompt, and **Notes**. Work on a self-portrait, a portrait of someone who agreed to be edited and shown in class, or the practice portraits. When we critique, we talk about the *edit*, never about anyone's looks.

MODULE PROGRESS TRACKER

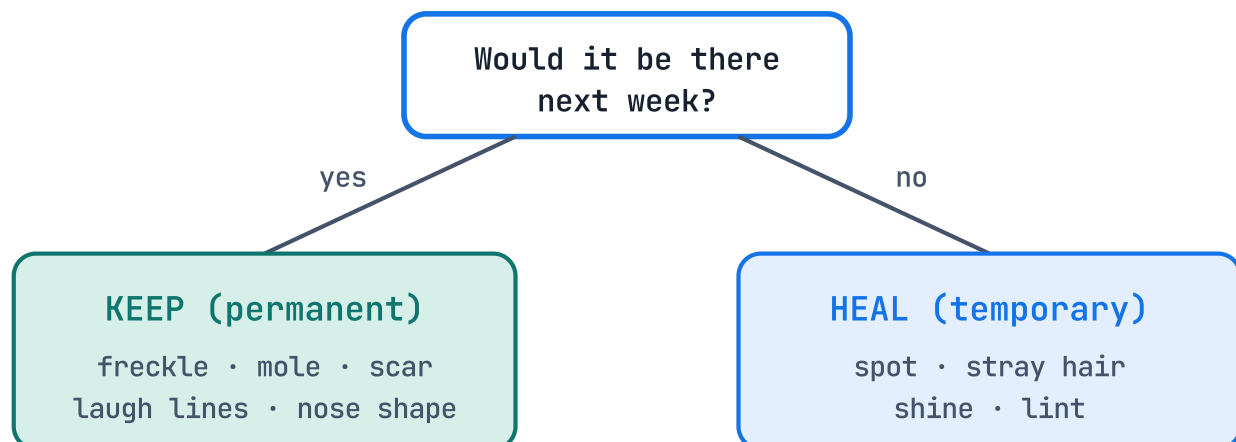
- ◆ ☐ **L08:** I healed only the temporary blemishes on a separate **retouch** layer and dialed it back
- ◆ ☐ **L09:** I built LOW and HIGH layers, evened the tone on LOW, and kept the pores crisp
- ◆ ☐ **L10:** I sculpted the face on a 50% gray Soft Light layer and exported **portrait-final.jpg**

◆ BY THE END YOU CAN

- ◆ Retouch skin non-destructively on a separate empty layer
- ◆ Remove temporary blemishes with the **Spot Healing Brush** and **Healing Brush**
- ◆ Decide what to fix and what to leave
- ◆ Dial back your work with layer opacity so it never looks overdone

◆ KEY IDEAS

- ◆ **Great retouching is invisible.** The person should look like themselves on a good day, not like a wax figure.
- ◆ Ask of every "flaw": **would it be there next week?** No → **temporary** (spot, stray hair, shine, lint): heal it. Yes → **permanent** (freckles, moles, laugh lines, scars, nose shape): keep it, or reduce it, never erase.
- ◆ **Survey before tools.** Zoom to 100% and sort what you see before touching anything.
- ◆ All healing goes on an empty **retouch layer**. **Spot Healing Brush**: tick **Sample All Layers**. **Healing Brush**: set **Sample: Current & Below**. They're separate settings.
- ◆ **Spot Healing** is one-click and picks its own source (open skin). The **Healing Brush** lets you choose the source with **Alt**/**⌘**-click (edges, hairlines).
- ◆ Lower the retouch layer to about **85–90% opacity** so a whisper of the original keeps it believable.



When unsure, lean toward keeping. You can always reduce later.

◆ WORKED EXAMPLE: CLEAN SKIN

- 1 Open the portrait. **File ▶ Save As** → `portrait-working.psd`.

- 2 Zoom to 100% (Ctrl/⌘ + 1) and pan slowly. Sort what you see: temporary or permanent.
- 3 New empty layer, name it **retouch**, and keep it selected.
- 4 **Spot Healing Brush (J): Type: Content-Aware, Sample All Layers ✓**. Brush just larger than each blemish; single-click.
- 5 Near an edge (hairline, eyebrow): **Healing Brush (Shift + J cycles the group), Sample: Current & Below. Alt/⌥-click** clean skin of the same brightness, then click the blemish. Still smearing? Finish with the **Clone Stamp (S)**, same Sample setting.
- 6 Retouch layer **Opacity** about 85–90%. Toggle its  to compare. Save.

◆ YOUR TURN: SURVEY AND SORT (BEFORE ANY TOOL)

At 100% zoom, list what you see on your portrait (or **108-portrait-blemishes.jpg**) in the correct column:

Temporary: heal

Permanent: keep

◆ YOUR TURN: RETOUCH CHECKLIST

- ◆ ☐ All healing is on the separate **retouch** layer (tools set to sample the layers below)
- ◆ ☐ Temporary blemishes are gone
- ◆ ☐ Freckles, moles, and lines are still there
- ◆ ☐ Retouch layer opacity is slightly under 100%
- ◆ ☐ With the retouch layer on, it still looks like the same person

◆ WATCH OUT

Brush does nothing? Check the options bar: Sample All Layers (Spot Healing) or Sample: Current & Below (Healing Brush). **Color patch after a heal?** It sampled a shadow or highlight; sample skin of the same brightness. **Tempted to remove every freckle?** Don't. That's what makes a face look plastic.

◆ SELF-CHECK

Q1

Using the temporary-vs-permanent test, which one should you heal?

- A) A cluster of freckles across the nose
- B) Laugh lines around the eyes
- C) A red spot that wasn't there last week

Q2

Why do all the healing on a separate, empty retouch layer?

- A) The original face is never touched, and the work can be reduced (opacity) or deleted later
- B) Healing tools only work on empty layers
- C) It makes the healing stronger

Q3

You switch to the Healing Brush on your empty retouch layer, Alt/⌘-click clean skin, click a blemish, and nothing useful happens. What's the likely cause?

- A) The brush is too soft
- B) Its Sample menu is on Current Layer, so it samples the empty layer; set it to Current & Below
- C) Healing only works at 100% zoom

Q4

A blemish sits right at the hairline and the Spot Healing Brush keeps smearing hair into the skin. What's the better approach?

- A) Make the Spot Healing Brush much bigger
- B) Leave it; hairline spots can't be fixed
- C) Switch to the Healing Brush and Alt/⌘-click clean skin nearby as the source

Q5

Why lower the retouch layer's opacity to about 85–90%?

- A) Letting a whisper of the original through keeps the result believable
- B) It makes the file smaller
- C) Photoshop requires it before saving

Q6

What's the very first step of a natural retouch?

- A) Run a Gaussian Blur over the face
- B) Survey the face at 100% and sort what you see into temporary and permanent
- C) Heal every mark you can find, then undo the ones you regret

◆ JOURNAL

Where's your personal line between "cleanup" and "changing who someone is"? Writing down your line now is worth revisiting later. Also note: key concepts · what clicked · questions · ideas to try · how you feel about your progress.

◆ NOTES

◆ BY THE END YOU CAN

- ◆ Explain **high frequency** (texture) vs **low frequency** (color and tone)
- ◆ Build the setup with **Gaussian Blur + Apply Image**
- ◆ Even out blotchy skin tone on the color layer, texture untouched
- ◆ Fix stray texture on the texture layer, color untouched

◆ KEY IDEAS

- ◆ Every image is two things layered together. **Low frequency**: the slow, soft stuff (overall color, shading, blotches): the *paint*. **High frequency**: the fast, fine stuff (pores, fine hairs, crisp edges): the *texture* stamped into it.
- ◆ Blurring a face smooths both at once, which is why it looks plastic. Frequency separation puts them on **two layers** so you can fix one without harming the other.
- ◆ **LOW** = a blurred copy (Normal mode). **HIGH** = the texture extracted with Apply Image, in **Linear Light** mode, on top. Together they look identical to the original.
- ◆ **Color on LOW, texture on HIGH: never mix them.**
- ◆ The Apply Image recipe depends on **bit depth** (Image ► Mode). 8-bit: Subtract, Scale 2, Offset 128. 16-bit: Add, Scale 2, Offset 0, Invert.

**HIGH • texture (pores)**

blend mode: Linear Light

**LOW • color & tone**

blend mode: Normal (blurred)

Original layers (untouched underneath)

Fix blotches on LOW with a soft brush or small blur; fix stray texture on HIGH with heal or clone.

◆ WORKED EXAMPLE: THE RECIPE CARD

- 1 Open your portrait from L08. **Stamp Visible:** Ctrl + Alt + Shift + E / ⌘ + ⌥ + ⇧ + E.
- 2 Duplicate it twice (Ctrl/⌘ + J ×2). Lower copy = **LOW**, upper copy = **HIGH**. Hide HIGH.
- 3 Select LOW: **Filter ▶ Blur ▶ Gaussian Blur** until blotches are gone and pores just disappear (often ~6–12 px).
- 4 Show and select HIGH: **Image ▶ Apply Image:** Layer **LOW**, Blending **Subtract**, Scale **2**, Offset **128** (8-bit). OK. HIGH turns flat gray.
- 5 Set HIGH's blend mode to **Linear Light**. The image looks normal again. ✓ Checkpoint.
- 6 On LOW: Lasso a blotchy area, **Select ▶ Modify ▶ Feather** 10–20 px, small Gaussian Blur. Or paint with a soft brush at low opacity, sampling good nearby color.
- 7 On HIGH: Healing Brush or Clone Stamp with **Sample: Current Layer** to remove a flyaway hair. Save.

◆ YOUR TURN: RECIPE FROM MEMORY

After the lab, close your notes and fill in the blanks:

Stamp Visible shortcut (my computer)	_____
Which copy is blurred?	_____
Apply Image, 8-bit: Blending / Scale / Offset	_____ / ____ / ____
HIGH's blend mode	_____
Where do I even out blotches?	_____
Where do I remove a stray hair, and with what Sample setting?	_____

◆ YOUR TURN: WHAT DID HIGH-OFF SHOW YOU?

Toggle HIGH's  off to see your pure color sheet, then on again. Describe the difference in a sentence or two:

◆ IF YOU GET A GRAY MESS

Check three things: HIGH's blend mode is **Linear Light**; Apply Image used **Layer: LOW**; the recipe matches **Image ▶ Mode** (8-bit vs 16-bit). Fastest fix: delete HIGH, duplicate the stamped layer again, redo the step. Everyone who does this professionally has seen that gray screen.

◆ SELF-CHECK

Q1

In frequency separation, what does the low-frequency layer hold?

- A) Pores, fine hairs, and crisp edges
- B) Color and tone: the blotches and shading
- C) Only the background

Q2

How much Gaussian Blur should the LOW layer get?

- A) Just until the blotches are gone and the pores just disappear, no more
- B) As much as possible, so the skin is perfectly smooth
- C) Exactly 50 px on every photo

Q3

For an 8-bit photo, which Apply Image settings build the HIGH layer?

- A) Add, Scale 1, Offset 0, then Normal mode
- B) Multiply, Scale 2, Offset 255, then Overlay
- C) Layer: LOW, Subtract, Scale 2, Offset 128, then set HIGH to Linear Light

Q4

Your HIGH layer is flat gray and the photo won't look normal again. What's the most likely cause?

- A) HIGH's blend mode isn't set to Linear Light (or you used the wrong recipe for the bit depth)
- B) The LOW layer isn't blurred enough
- C) You're zoomed out too far

Q5

A flyaway hair crosses the forehead. How do you remove it without shifting color?

A) Paint over it on LOW with a soft brush

B) Healing Brush or Clone Stamp on HIGH, with Sample: Current Layer

C) Healing Brush on HIGH with Sample: All Layers

Q6

Why not just run a big Gaussian Blur on the whole face?

A) Gaussian Blur can't be undone

B) It would make the file too large

C) Blur smooths texture and color together, so the pores vanish and skin looks plastic

◆ JOURNAL

Frequency separation is the first technique in this course that feels genuinely "advanced." How did it feel to pull it off? Note any step you'd want to re-read: that's your cue for a second practice run. Also note: key concepts · what clicked · questions · ideas to try · how you feel about your progress.

LEARN IT AS A RECIPE; UNDERSTANDING FOLLOWS

"Frequency," "Apply Image," and "Linear Light" sound technical, but you set them once and forget them. Run the full setup two more times this week and the recipe will be memorized. Most people who own Photoshop never learn this. You just did.

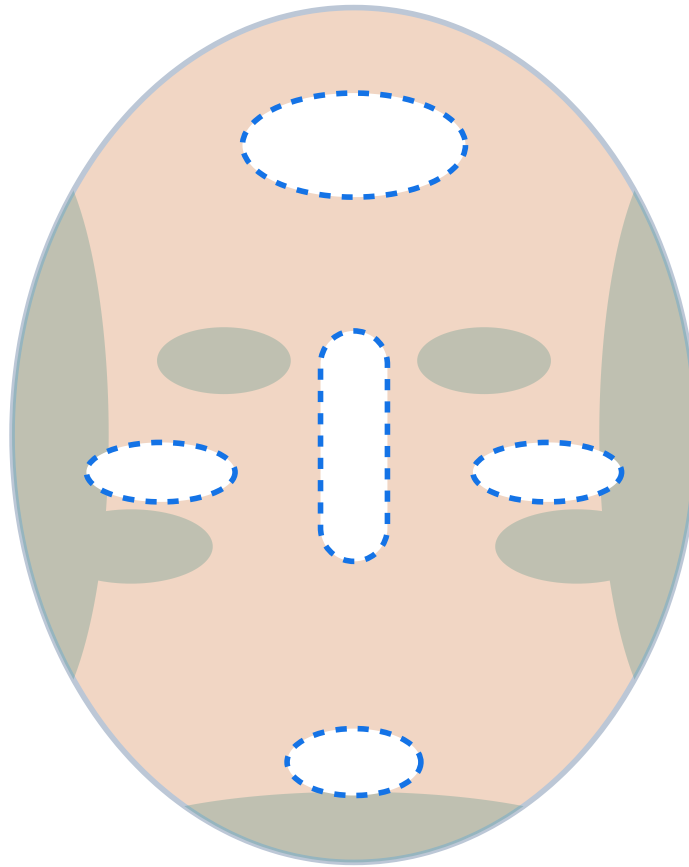
◆ NOTES

◆ BY THE END YOU CAN

- ◆ Sculpt a face by **dodging** (lightening) and **burning** (darkening)
- ◆ Do it non-destructively on a **50% gray Soft Light** layer
- ◆ Add subtle life to eyes and teeth with masked adjustments
- ◆ Finish and export a complete, natural portrait retouch

◆ KEY IDEAS

- ◆ **Dodge** = lighten, **burn** = darken. You're a lighting artist adding highlights and shadows after the shot.
- ◆ Faces look 3D because the **brow, nose bridge, cheekbones and chin** catch light, and the **sides, temples, eye sockets and under the jaw** fall into shadow.
- ◆ On a **50% gray layer in Soft Light** mode, gray is invisible. Paint **white** to dodge, **black** to burn. Non-destructive and re-editable.
- ◆ **~10% brush opacity, many passes.** You can always add more; you can't un-see a harsh streak.
- ◆ **Follow the existing light.** If light comes from the left, dodge the left-facing planes and burn the right.
- ◆ Finish with a slightly brightened, **masked Curves** layer on the eye whites and teeth: clean, not glowing.



dodge
(white)

burn
(black)

Dashed white = catch-light zones to dodge. Shaded = shadow zones to burn.

◆ WORKED EXAMPLE: SCULPT & FINISH

- 1 **Alt/⌘**-click the **New Layer** button. **Mode: Soft Light**, tick **Fill with Soft-Light-neutral color (50% gray)**. Name it **D&B**. It looks invisible: correct.
- 2 Brush (**B**), soft and large, **Opacity ~10%**. Press **D**, then **X** so white is the foreground. Dodge the catch-light zones with repeated light strokes.
- 3 Press **X** for black. Burn the shadow zones.
- 4 Add a Curves layer, brighten slightly, fill its mask black, paint white over the eye whites and teeth. (Optional: a second tiny Curves layer masked to the irises for a little sparkle.)
- 5 Fit to screen. **File ▶ Save the .psd**, then **File ▶ Export ▶ Export As (JPG, about 80%) → portrait-final.jpg**.

Want to see your light "map"? **Alt/⌘**-click the D&B layer's  to show it alone, then **Alt/⌘**-click again to return.

◆ YOUR TURN: READ THE LIGHT FIRST

Before you paint: where does the light in your portrait come from (left, right, above, front)? Which side of the face is brighter? Write it here, then list the three zones you'll dodge and the three you'll burn.

◆ YOUR TURN: FINISH CHECKLIST

- ◆ ☐ Dodge & burn lives on a 50% gray Soft Light layer
- ◆ ☐ Highlights and shadows follow the photo's existing light
- ◆ ☐ The face looks more three-dimensional, not painted-on
- ◆ ☐ Eyes and teeth subtly brightened with a masked Curves layer
- ◆ ☐ Saved the `.psd` master and exported `portrait-final.jpg`

◆ SELF-CHECK

Q1

On a 50% gray layer set to Soft Light, what does painting with white do?

- A) Darkens (burns) that area
- B) Lightens (dodges) that area
- C) Turns that area white

Q2

Why use a 50% gray layer in Soft Light mode instead of an empty Normal layer?

- A) Gray paint is faster to apply
- B) Soft Light brightens the whole photo automatically
- C) 50% gray is invisible in Soft Light, so only your light and dark strokes show, and it stays re-editable

Q3

Which brush setup matches the lesson?

- A) Large, soft brush at about 10% opacity, building up with many passes
- B) Small, hard brush at 100% opacity
- C) Any brush, as long as you paint only once

Q4

In your portrait the light comes from the left. How should you dodge and burn?

- A) Dodge the right side to even it out
- B) Dodge the left-facing planes and burn the right, enhancing the existing light
- C) Invent a new light from above

Q5

How does the lesson brighten the eyes and teeth?

- A) Paint pure white directly over them on the portrait layer
- B) Raise the whole image's Exposure
- C) A slightly brightened Curves layer with its mask filled black, then white painted over the eye whites and teeth

Q6

Why is the gray layer the pro default over the Dodge and Burn tools?

- A) The tools paint directly on pixels (destructive); the gray layer stays re-editable
- B) The Dodge and Burn tools were removed from Photoshop
- C) The tools only work on 16-bit images

◆ JOURNAL

You've now finished a full portrait retouch. Compare it honestly to your very first Module 0 export. What can you do now that you couldn't three modules ago? Also note: key concepts · what clicked · questions · ideas to try · how you feel about your progress.

◆ NOTES

YOU FINISHED MODULE 3 🎉

You can retouch a portrait end to end the way professionals do: heal the temporary and respect the permanent, even skin tone without going plastic, and sculpt dimension with light, all non-destructive. The jump from "editing a photo" to "sculpting a portrait" is a big one, and you made it. Before Session 5: retouch one more portrait start to finish, subtle enough that a friend wouldn't notice it was retouched, only that it looks great.

Compositing

Two images in, one believable photograph out. You will cut a subject out cleanly, teach it the scene's light and color, then ground it with shadow and unify it with one grade. It is one file, built across three lessons, so save often.

Lessons 11–13

3 lessons

Session 5

Name: _____

HOW TO USE THIS WORKBOOK

Each lesson has **By the end you can**, **Key ideas**, a **Worked example**, a **Your turn** activity (do it in Photoshop and write what happened), a **Self-check**, a **Journal** prompt, and **Notes**. Shortcuts are written **Windows / Mac**. Your practice files are in `labs/module-4/practice/`, or use your own photos.

GROWTH MINDSET: SEEING IS THE SKILL

The first time you zoom in on a cutout and spot the fringe, it can feel like you did something wrong. You didn't. You just learned to **see** a flaw most people never notice, and seeing a bad edge is half of fixing one. Every composite you finish trains your eye a little more.

MODULE PROGRESS TRACKER

- ◆ ☐ **L11**: my subject is on its own layer with a mask, fringe-free against a saturated test color
- ◆ ☐ **L12**: my subject matches the scene's brightness, color, and contrast, all adjustments clipped
- ◆ ☐ **L13**: contact + cast shadows, subtle haze, one grade on top; master saved, JPG exported 🏆

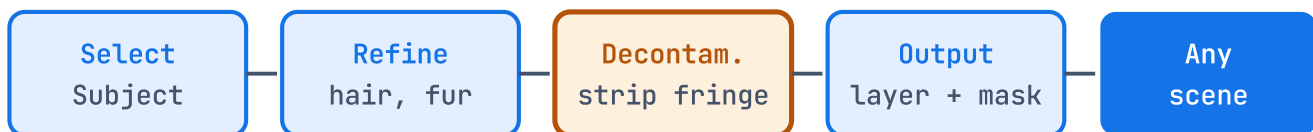
◆ BY THE END YOU CAN

- ◆ Cut a subject out with **Select & Mask**, tuned for compositing
- ◆ Rescue fine hair with the **Refine Edge Brush**
- ◆ Kill the fringe with **Decontaminate Colors**
- ◆ Output a **new layer with a layer mask**, ready for any scene

◆ KEY IDEAS

- ◆ **The background tells on you.** Edge pixels picked up color from whatever was behind the subject. On a new scene, that leftover color shows as a **fringe** (a halo).
- ◆ A composite cutout has two jobs: choose the right pixels, *and* clean the old color out of the edge.
- ◆ **Decontaminate Colors** strips that fringe. It rewrites edge pixels, so Photoshop forces the result onto a **new layer**; keep your original as a hidden backup.
- ◆ The **Refine Edge Brush** is for soft, wispy edges (hair, fur) only. On a hard edge it turns detail to mush.

the step beginners skip



The composite cutout pipeline. Decontamination is the step pros never skip.

◆ WORKED EXAMPLE: THE SETTINGS THAT MATTER

- 1 Select ► **Subject**, then Select ► **Select and Mask...** (Ctrl+Alt+R / ⌘+⌘+R). View: **On Layers** or **Overlay**.
- 2 **Refine Hair** (options bar). Edge Detection: tick **Smart Radius**, raise **Radius** a few pixels.
- 3 **Refine Edge Brush** along wispy hair. **Shift Edge** slightly negative. Smooth and Feather at or near 0 on hair.
- 4 Output Settings: tick **Decontaminate Colors**, raise **Amount** until the halo disappears (the lesson's diagram shows 90%).
- 5 **Output To: New Layer with Layer Mask** → OK. Group it, name the group **SUBJECT**, keep the original hidden below. Save as `composite-working.psd`.

◆ YOUR TURN: A COMPOSITE-READY CUTOUT

Cut out your subject (or `111-figure-on-green.png`). Then run the **believability test**: add Layer ► New Fill Layer ► Solid Color in a wild color and drag it under the cutout. Record:

Subject I used

Where the fringe showed before
decontaminating

Decontaminate Amount that removed it

Test colors I tried (aim for three)

- ◆ ☐ Subject on its own layer with a mask (background hidden, not deleted)
- ◆ ☐ Hair edges look soft and natural, not chopped
- ◆ ☐ No colored fringe against a saturated test background
- ◆ ☐ Original layer kept as a hidden backup
- ◆ ☐ Cutout group named and saved

◆ WATCH OUT

Don't over-brush. The Refine Edge Brush on a shoulder or jaw turns crisp detail to mush. And it cannot invent hair the original selection never included: fix the selection first.

◆ SELF-CHECK

Q1

Your cutout looked perfect on its original background but looks "pasted" on a sunset. What is the most likely cause?

- A) The subject's resolution is too low
- B) The edge pixels still carry color from the old background (a fringe)
- C) The layer mask is set to the wrong blend mode

Q2

What does Decontaminate Colors do?

- A) Removes noise from the whole photo
- B) Replaces the old background's color in the edge pixels so the edge can adopt the new scene
- C) Converts the image to black and white

Q3

With Decontaminate Colors ticked, which Output To setting does the lesson use?

- A) Selection
- B) Layer Mask
- C) New Layer with Layer Mask

Q4

Where should you paint with the Refine Edge Brush?

- A) Along every edge, including shoulders and jaws
- B) Only on soft, wispy edges like hair and fur
- C) Only inside the subject, to fill holes

Q5

What is the lesson's "believability test" for a finished cutout?

- A) Drop a saturated colored layer behind it and check whether a fringe appears
- B) Zoom out to 25% and see if it looks okay
- C) Turn the layer mask off and on

Q6

What is the keyboard shortcut for Select and Mask?

A) Ctrl+J / ⌘+J

B) Ctrl+Alt+G / ⌘+⌥+G

C) Ctrl+Alt+R / ⌘+⌥+R

◆ JOURNAL

Before today, would you have noticed a fringe on a cutout? Now that you can see it, you cannot unsee it. Note one composite in the wild (an ad, a meme, a movie poster) where the cutout betrays itself. Also note: key concepts · what clicked · questions · ideas to try · your progress and feelings.

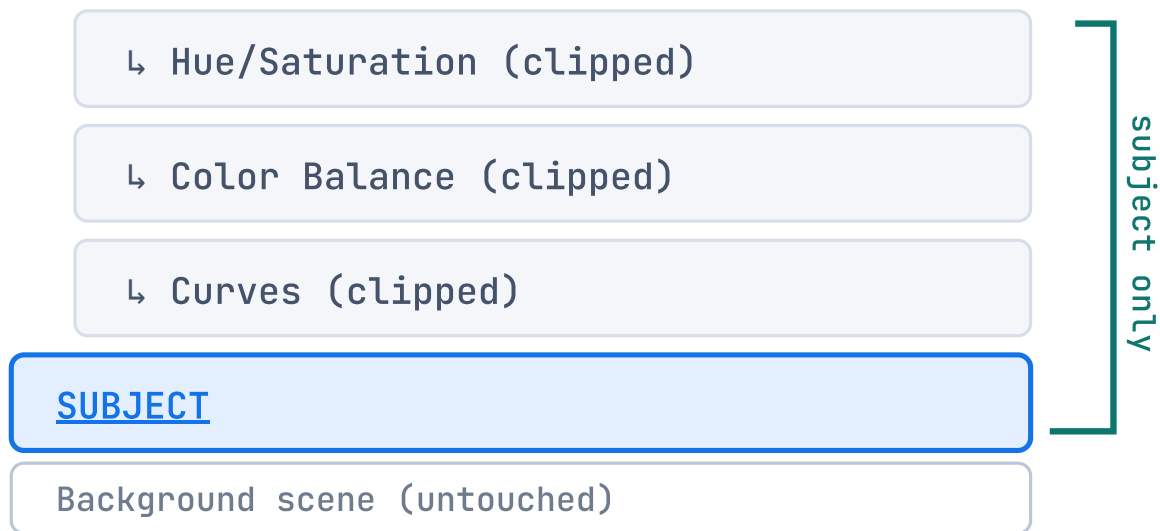
◆ NOTES

◆ BY THE END YOU CAN

- ◆ Diagnose a "pasted" look by checking **brightness, color, and contrast**
- ◆ Match the subject with **clipped adjustment layers**
- ◆ Pull the scene's color into the subject with **Curves** and **Color Balance**

◆ KEY IDEAS

- ◆ Everything in a real scene shares the same light, like a shared **accent**. A pasted subject has a foreign accent.
- ◆ **One rule:** match **brightness** first, **color** second, **contrast** third. Brightness alone often does eighty percent of the work.
- ◆ A **clipped** adjustment affects only the layer directly below it. Clip with **Ctrl+Alt+G** / **⌘+⌘+G**, or **Alt/⌘-** click the line between the two layers. A clipped layer shows an indent and a bent arrow (↳); the layer it clips to has its name underlined.
- ◆ **Warm light usually means cool shadows.** Warm the lit side; don't dip the whole subject in orange.



Every adjustment clipped to SUBJECT; the background never changes.

◆ WORKED EXAMPLE: DIAGNOSING A PASTED SUBJECT

A subject shot in a cool, bright studio is dropped into a warm, hazy sunset. Ask the three questions in order:

QUESTION	WHAT YOU SEE	CLIPPED FIX
1 · Brightness	Subject brighter than everything around it	Curves: pull the curve down until it sits in the scene's range (squint to check)
2 · Color	Subject bluish; scene orange	Color Balance: add red and yellow in midtones and highlights; a touch cooler in the shadows
3 · Contrast	Subject crisp and saturated; scene soft	Curves: flatten contrast a little; Hue/Saturation: Saturation down a few points

◆ YOUR TURN: MATCH THE SUBJECT

File ► Place Embedded your background (or `112-scene-sunset.jpg`), press Enter, drag it below **SUBJECT**. Right-click the group ► **Convert to Smart Object**, then `Ctrl/⌘+T` to size it with its feet on the ground. Match in order. Before you touch a slider, write your diagnosis:

Brightness: too bright, too dark, or matched?

Scene temperature (warm / cool / neutral)

Scene contrast (soft and hazy / punchy and crisp)

- ◆ ☐ Sized and positioned believably (feet on the ground)
- ◆ ☐ Brightness matches nearby scene elements
- ◆ ☐ The lit side carries the scene's color; shadows are not over-warmed
- ◆ ☐ Contrast and saturation match the scene
- ◆ ☐ Every adjustment is clipped (`⌘+L`), background untouched

Squint-and-flick test: squint at the whole image, then toggle all your clipped layers off and on. The "off" version should look obviously wrong.

◆ SELF-CHECK

Q1

In what order does the lesson match a subject to a scene?

- A) Brightness, then color, then contrast
- B) Color, then contrast, then brightness
- C) Contrast, then brightness, then color

Q2

What does clipping an adjustment layer do?

- A) Hides the adjustment until you click it
- B) Merges the adjustment into the layer permanently
- C) Limits the adjustment to the one layer directly below it

Q3

Which shortcut clips the active layer to the layer below?

- A) Ctrl+T / ⌘+T
- B) Ctrl+Alt+G / ⌘+⌥+G
- C) Ctrl+Shift+N / ⌘+⇧+N

Q4

You warmed your subject evenly for a sunset and now it looks "dipped in orange." What does the lesson suggest?

- A) Remove all the warmth and start over
- B) Add a touch of the opposite (cooler) temperature to the shadow side
- C) Warm the background even more to match

Q5

Why convert the **SUBJECT** group to a Smart Object before scaling it?

- A) So resizing never degrades it
- B) So adjustment layers can't affect it
- C) So it automatically matches the scene's color

Q6

How can you judge a scene's color temperature, according to the lesson?

A) Check the file's metadata

B) Look only at the subject's skin

C) Read the highlights and shadows on existing objects, or sample a neutral surface with the eyedropper

◆ JOURNAL

Which of the three (brightness, color, contrast) was hardest for your eye to judge? That is the one worth training with a few extra composites. Also note: key concepts · what clicked · questions · ideas to try · your progress and feelings.

◆ NOTES

◆ BY THE END YOU CAN

- ◆ Anchor a subject with a **contact shadow** and a soft **cast shadow**
- ◆ Add depth with **atmospheric perspective** (haze)
- ◆ Tie everything together with **one unifying grade**
- ◆ Save a layered master and **export** a finished composite

◆ KEY IDEAS

- ◆ **Shadow (the object):** nothing real floats. A contact shadow is the strongest single cue that a subject belongs.
- ◆ **Depth (the space):** distant things are hazier, lighter, and lower in contrast. A whisper of haze restores distance.
- ◆ **Unity (the whole):** one grade over everything gives the image a single shared look, like one camera and lens.
- ◆ **One light, one shadow direction.** If the sun is high-right, shadows fall low-left.

Unifying Grade (over ALL)

grade on top

Atmosphere / haze

► SUBJECT (group)

Contact Shadow (tight, never blurred)

Cast Shadow (soft, blurred)

shadows
below

Background scene

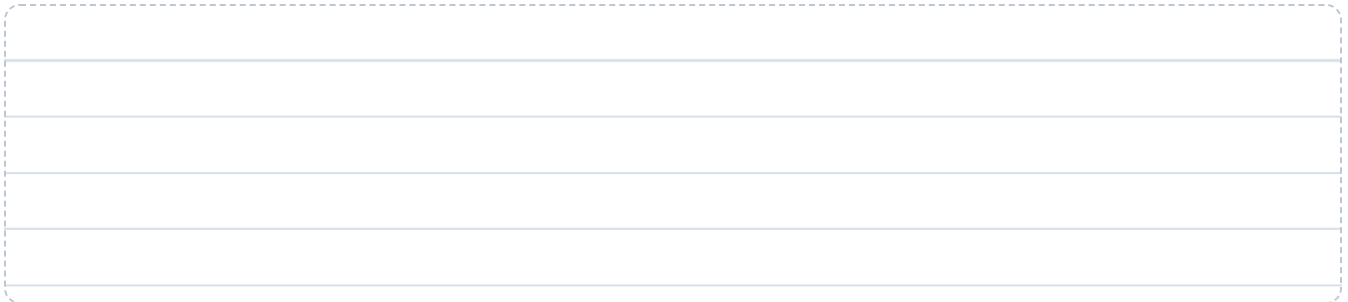
Shadows under, grade over, one light for all.

◆ WORKED EXAMPLE: THE FINISHING MOVES

- 1 New layer **below** the subject, named **Contact Shadow**. Soft black brush, low opacity: a small, dark pool right where the feet touch the ground. Never blur this layer.
- 2 New layer just below that, named **Cast Shadow**. A longer, softer shadow away from the light, lighter as it travels. Blur only this layer: Filter ► Blur ► Gaussian Blur.
- 3 For a mid or far subject: a low-opacity soft layer of the scene's haze color, masked to the distance.
- 4 At the very top: a **Color Lookup** or gentle **Curves** for one shared mood, plus a vignette (new layer, big soft black brush on the corners, lower the opacity).
- 5 File ► Save the layered master. File ► Export ► Export As ► JPG (flattened automatically).

◆ YOUR TURN: FIND THE LIGHT, THEN FINISH

Before painting any shadow, study your background. Sketch the scene below: draw an arrow for where the light comes from and the direction the existing shadows fall. Then mark where your subject's contact and cast shadows will go.



- ◆ ☐ A dark, tight contact shadow where the subject meets the ground
- ◆ ☐ A softer, blurred cast shadow on its own layer, same direction as the scene's shadows
- ◆ ☐ Distance reads through subtle atmosphere
- ◆ ☐ One unifying grade over the whole stack
- ◆ ☐ Layered master saved; finished JPG exported 🏆

◆ WATCH OUT

A fake-looking shadow is usually **too uniform**: vary it from dark and sharp at the contact point to soft and light at the tip. And if you can clearly see your haze or your grade, it's too strong. Both are whispers.

◆ SELF-CHECK

Q1

According to the lesson, what is the strongest single cue that a subject belongs in a scene?

- A) A strong vignette
- B) A contact shadow where the subject meets the ground
- C) Heavy atmospheric haze

Q2

Why do the contact shadow and the cast shadow go on separate layers?

- A) So you can blur the cast shadow without softening the contact point
- B) Because Photoshop can't paint two shadows on one layer
- C) So each can have a different blend mode for color

Q3

The sun in your background is high and to the right. Which way should your subject's cast shadow fall?

- A) High-right, toward the sun
- B) Straight up
- C) Low-left, away from the sun

Q4

Compared with nearby things, how do distant things look in a real scene?

- A) Darker, sharper, and more saturated
- B) Hazier, lighter, and lower in contrast
- C) Exactly the same

Q5

Where does the unifying grade go in the layer stack?

- A) At the very top, over everything
- B) Clipped to the subject
- C) Directly above the background, below the subject

Q6

What is the correct way to finish and deliver the composite?

- A) Flatten the image, then save over the .psd
- B) Save the layered .psd master, then File ► Export ► Export As a JPG
- C) Screenshot the canvas

◆ JOURNAL

Of shadow, atmosphere, and grade, which made the biggest difference to your composite? That tells you which cue your eye is most sensitive to. Also note: key concepts · what clicked · questions · ideas to try · your progress and feelings.

◆ NOTES

MODULE 4 SUMMARY

- ◆ A composite cutout must survive a new background; **Decontaminate Colors** strips the fringe.
- ◆ A pasted look is a mismatch of **brightness, color, or contrast**. Fix them in that order, every adjustment **clipped** to the subject.

- ◆ A **contact shadow** grounds the subject; **haze** adds depth; **one grade** on top unifies the whole.
- ◆ There is only one light: every shadow falls the same way.

YOU FINISHED MODULE 4 🎉

You took two separate images and made one believable photograph. That draws on every module so far: layers, masks, Curves, and painting light. Keep your exported JPG: in Module 5 you design a poster, and your composite can be its hero image.

Design & Type

Welcome to design. You will build a poster in one file across three lessons: words with a clear reading order, crisp vector shapes, then polish with layer styles and a correct export. Finishing it completes the Practitioner tier.

Lessons 14–16

3 lessons

Session 6

Name: _____

HOW TO USE THIS WORKBOOK

Each lesson has **By the end you can**, **Key ideas**, a **Worked example**, a **Your turn** activity, a **Self-check**, a **Journal** prompt, and **Notes**. Shortcuts are written **Windows / Mac**. Practice files are in `labs/module-5/practice/`; your Module 4 composite makes a great hero image.

GROWTH MINDSET: DESIGN IS RULES, NOT TALENT

"I have no eye for design" almost always means "nobody told me the rules." Hierarchy is a rule. Restraint is a rule. The Pen's two-move rule is a rule. Your first Pen curves will be lumpy, and that's normal: the Pen rewards practice more than any tool in Photoshop.

MODULE PROGRESS TRACKER

- ◆ ☐ **L14**: every line has a job; bold title; deliberate leading and tracking; type on a path
- ◆ ☐ **L15**: vector frame, combined-shape badge, one Pen shape, a path reused as a mask
- ◆ ☐ **L16**: restrained layer styles, reused style, Smart Object logo; poster exported 🏆

◆ BY THE END YOU CAN

- ◆ Set and edit text with the **Type tool** (point type vs paragraph type)
- ◆ Build a clear **hierarchy** with size, weight, and spacing
- ◆ Control **tracking, kerning, and leading** in the Character panel
- ◆ Curve text with **type on a path**

◆ KEY IDEAS

- ◆ **Type has a job:** grab attention, give the key detail, or be the fine print. Size and space each line to its job.
- ◆ **Size** reads first. **Weight:** bold pulls forward, light recedes. **Space:** room around a line makes it feel important.
- ◆ **Point type** (single click) for short display lines. **Paragraph type** (click and drag a box) for text that wraps.
- ◆ **Two fonts, maximum. One accent color** on the most important thing.

TERM	WHAT IT SPACES	REACH FOR IT WHEN...
Leading	Between lines of text	A headline's lines drift apart or crash together
Tracking	Evenly across a run of letters	A small all-caps label needs to breathe
Kerning	Between one specific pair	Two big display letters look awkwardly gapped

1st

SUMMER
MUSIC FESTIVAL

size

2nd

July 18 · Riverside Park

accent

3rd

Live bands · Food trucks · All ages

smaller

4th

TICKETS AT THE DOOR

tracked caps

Hierarchy is a planned reading order: you decide the path the eye takes.

◆ WORKED EXAMPLE: STARTING THE POSTER

- 1 File ► New: 18 × 24 inches at 150 ppi, dark background. Save as `poster-working.psd`.
- 2 Type tool (T): click once, type the event name. Commit with `Ctrl/⌘+Enter`, `Esc`, or the ✓. Click an **empty** spot for each other line (clicking existing text edits it).
- 3 Size by reading order: title boldly biggest, then date/place, details, fine print.
- 4 Window ► Character: tighten the title's leading; add tracking (for example +120) to small all-caps labels.
- 5 Type on a path: Ellipse tool in **Path** mode, drag a circle, hover the Type tool until the cursor shows a wavy line, click and type. Drag with Path Selection to slide or flip it.

◆ YOUR TURN: GIVE EVERY LINE A JOB

Use the copy from `l14-poster-copy.txt` or your own event. Plan the hierarchy **before** you touch Photoshop:

ORDER	LINE OF TEXT	ITS JOB	SIZE (PT)
1st			
2nd			
3rd			
4th			

My two fonts: _____ and _____ · My one accent color goes on:

- ◆ ☐ Every line is its own type layer with a clear job
- ◆ ☐ The 1st line is boldly bigger than the rest
- ◆ ☐ Leading and tracking set deliberately, not left at default
- ◆ ☐ Only one or two fonts, and one accent color
- ◆ ☐ At least one element uses type on a path

◆ SELF-CHECK

Q1

Which kind of type should you use for a big poster title?

- A) Point type (a single click)
- B) Paragraph type (drag a text box)
- C) Either one; they behave the same

Q2

What does leading control?

- A) The space between one specific pair of letters
- B) The space between lines of text
- C) The thickness of the letters

Q3

A small all-caps label like "TICKETS AT THE DOOR" looks cramped. What's the fix from the lesson?

- A) Make it bold
- B) Tighten the leading
- C) Add positive tracking

Q4

What is the most common fix on a beginner poster?

- A) Make the main line much bigger
- B) Add more fonts for variety
- C) Put the accent color on every line

Q5

How many fonts does the lesson recommend on one poster?

A) As many as the lines of text

B) One or two

C) At least four, for contrast

Q6

Your text on a circular path is upside down along the bottom. What do you do?

A) Delete it and draw the circle again

B) Rotate the whole layer 180°

C) Drag across the path with the Path Selection tool to flip it, then reposition

◆ JOURNAL

Did "I have no eye for design" ever apply to you? After building one real hierarchy, does it feel more like a set of rules you can follow? Write down the one rule that surprised you most. Also note: key concepts · what clicked · questions · ideas to try · your progress and feelings.

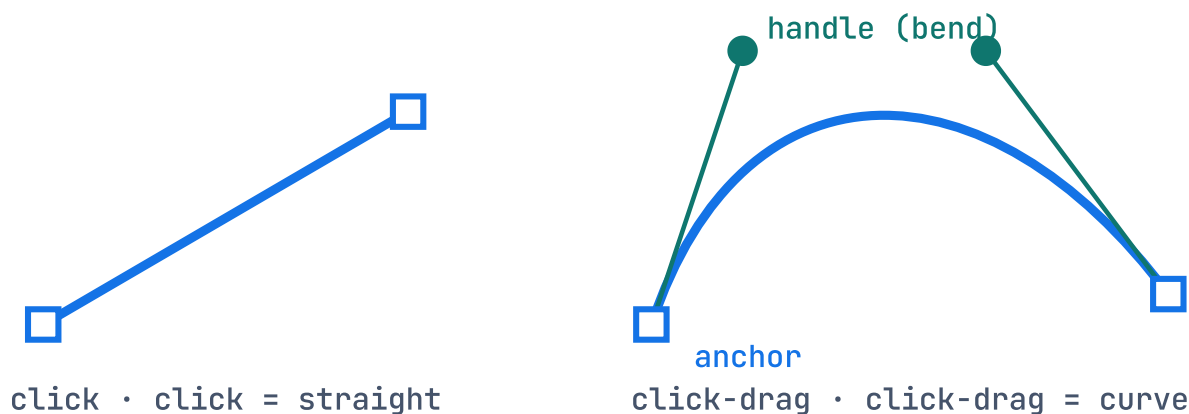
◆ NOTES

◆ BY THE END YOU CAN

- ◆ Explain **vector vs raster**, and why vectors never pixelate
- ◆ Draw and combine **shape layers**
- ◆ Use the **Pen** for clean straight and curved paths
- ◆ Turn paths into **shapes, selections, or masks**

◆ KEY IDEAS

- ◆ **Raster** (a photo) is a grid of pixels: enlarge it and it goes soft or blocky. **Vector** is stored as math, redrawn crisp at any size. Type is vector too.
- ◆ Use vector for **type, logos, icons, frames, badges**; raster for photos.
- ◆ **The two-move rule**: straight line = click, click. Curve = click and drag, then click and drag again.
- ◆ **Fewer points, smoother curves**: one anchor wherever the curve changes direction, no more.
- ◆ **Modes matter**: Shape mode makes a shape layer; Path mode makes a Work Path in the Paths panel.



Anchors (squares) are where the path passes; handles (dots) control the bend.

◆ WORKED EXAMPLE: FRAME, BADGE, CUSTOM SHAPE

- 1 **Frame**: Rectangle tool, **Shape** mode. Fill: none (white box with a red slash). Stroke: a few pixels, accent color.
- 2 **Badge**: draw an Ellipse shape. With that layer active, pick **Path Operations** ► Combine Shapes / Subtract Front Shape / Intersect Shape Areas **before** drawing the next shape (or hold **Shift** to add, **Alt**/**⌘** to subtract as you start dragging).

- 3 **Pen shape:** Pen in **Shape** mode. Click for corners, click-and-drag for curves. Refine with the **Direct Selection** tool (white arrow).
- 4 **Path triple duty:** Pen in **Path** mode, draw a closed path (a Work Path). Right-click it: Make Selection, Fill Path, Stroke Path, Create Vector Mask. Make Selection → Add Layer Mask.
- 5 **Scale test:** duplicate a small shape, right-click the copy ► Rasterize Layer, scale both about 400% with `Ctrl/⌘+T`, compare at 100%.

◆ YOUR TURN: THE PEN GAME

Open `115-pen-practice.png` and trace each shape with the Pen in Shape mode, using as few anchor points as you can. Record your count (fewer is better):

SHAPE	SUGGESTED POINTS	MY FIRST TRY	MY BEST
Lightning bolt (corners only)	see sheet		
Mountain range (corners only)	see sheet		
Leaf (2 corners + curves)	see sheet		
Heart	see sheet		

Then add to your poster:

- ◆ ☐ A vector frame with a stroke and no fill
- ◆ ☐ A badge built from combined shapes
- ◆ ☐ One custom shape drawn with the Pen (few, clean anchor points)
- ◆ ☐ Edges stay crisp after scaling up 400% (the rasterized copy does not)
- ◆ ☐ At least one path reused as a selection or mask

◆ WATCH OUT

Nothing appeared in the Layers panel? Your Pen is in **Path** mode: look in the Paths panel, or switch the options bar to **Shape**. Lumpy curve? Delete extra anchor points and keep handles roughly tangent to the curve.

◆ SELF-CHECK

Q1

Why does a vector shape stay crisp when you enlarge it?

- A) Photoshop sharpens it automatically
- B) It is stored as math (instructions) and redrawn fresh at any size
- C) It has more pixels than a photo

Q2

What is the Pen's "two-move rule"?

- A) Click for corners; click and drag for curves
- B) Drag for corners; double-click for curves
- C) Draw freehand, then smooth it

Q3

Your Pen curve looks lumpy. What's the most likely cause?

- A) The stroke is too thin
- B) The document resolution is too low
- C) Too many anchor points

Q4

You draw a closed shape with the Pen set to Path mode. Where does it appear?

- A) As a new shape layer in the Layers panel
- B) As a Work Path in the Paths panel, not as a new layer
- C) Nowhere until you save

Q5

How do you prove a shape layer stays sharp and a rasterized copy doesn't?

- A) Scale both up about 400% with Ctrl/⌘+T and compare at 100% zoom
- B) Zoom in to 800% on both
- C) Change both colors

Q6

To subtract a small circle from your badge on the same shape layer, when do you choose Subtract Front Shape?

- A) After drawing both shapes on separate layers
- B) Only after rasterizing the badge
- C) With the badge layer active, before drawing the second shape

◆ JOURNAL

The Pen tool has a reputation for being hard. After the two-move rule (click for corners, drag for curves), does it feel less mysterious? Note the shape you found hardest to trace and why. Also note: key concepts · what clicked · questions · ideas to try · your progress and feelings.

◆ NOTES

◆ BY THE END YOU CAN

- ◆ Apply **layer styles** (Drop Shadow, Stroke, Gradient Overlay) as live effects
- ◆ **Copy and paste** styles across layers
- ◆ Use **Smart Objects** for logos and repeated graphics
- ◆ Assemble a poster and **export for print vs screen**

◆ KEY IDEAS

- ◆ A **layer style** lives on the layer as a live "fx": edit the text or recolor the shape and the effects update. Same non-destructive idea as adjustment layers and Smart Filters (Module 2).
- ◆ **Restraint wins.** A gradient and a soft shadow is usually enough; two or three effects per layer at most. Heavy bevels and glows read as amateur fast.
- ◆ Open Layer Style by **double-clicking a layer to the right of its name**. Tick an effect to enable it; click its name to see its controls.
- ◆ **Keep your layered .psd as the master. Always.**

DESTINATION	COLOR MODE	RESOLUTION	FORMAT
Print	CMYK (ask the printer)	300 ppi at final size	PDF (PDF/X, per the printer) or TIFF
Screen / social	RGB	Pixel dimensions that fit the platform (ppi doesn't matter on screen)	JPG or PNG

◆ WORKED EXAMPLE: POLISH AND EXPORT

- 1 **Title:** Layer Style ► Gradient Overlay (two tones of the accent) + Drop Shadow (low opacity, small distance, moderate size).
- 2 **Badge:** Stroke + soft Drop Shadow. Right-click its **fx** ► Copy Layer Style; right-click another layer ► Paste Layer Style.
- 3 **Smart Objects:** File ► Place Embedded brings a logo or photo in as a Smart Object. Put a hero image behind the type.
- 4 **Assemble:** Move tool with smart guides; even margins; squint.
- 5 **Screen:** File ► Export ► Export As ► JPG (PNG if you need transparency).

- 6 **Print:** get the printer's spec sheet → Image ► Canvas Size to add the bleed on every side (often 0.125 in / 3 mm), extend the background, keep type well inside the trim → Edit ► Convert to Profile on a copy (or let a PDF/X preset convert) → File ► Save a Copy as Photoshop PDF with the printer's preset.

◆ YOUR TURN: FINISH THE POSTER

For each layer that has a style, list its effects. More than three? Ask what each one is really doing.

LAYER	EFFECTS USED	REMOVED FOR RESTRAINT
Title		
Badge		

- ◆ ☐ The title has a gradient and a subtle drop shadow
- ◆ ☐ A consistent style is reused (copy/paste layer style)
- ◆ ☐ Reusable graphics are Smart Objects
- ◆ ☐ Effects are restrained (two or three per layer at most)
- ◆ ☐ Everything aligned with even margins
- ◆ ☐ Screen JPG exported and viewed at full size 🏆
- ◆ ☐ (Homework) print-ready PDF: bleed added, CMYK per printer, layered .psd kept

◆ WATCH OUT

Scaled a layer and now the stroke looks too thin? Effects keep their pixel values when you transform. Right-click the fx ► **Scale Effects**. Print looks different from your screen? Soft-proof with View ► Proof Setup and View ► Proof Colors (Ctrl/⌘+Y), and confirm with the printer.

◆ SELF-CHECK

Q1

What is a layer style?

- A) A filter that permanently changes the layer's pixels
- B) A preset font and size
- C) A set of live, re-editable effects attached to the layer

Q2

How do you reuse the exact look of one styled layer on another?

- A) Right-click its fx ► Copy Layer Style, then right-click the other layer ► Paste Layer Style
- B) Merge the two layers
- C) Rebuild every effect from memory

Q3

Which title treatment does the lesson recommend?

- A) Bevel & Emboss + Outer Glow + Stroke + Drop Shadow
- B) Gradient Overlay + a subtle Drop Shadow
- C) No styles at all, ever

Q4

You're exporting the poster for social media. Which settings are right?

- A) RGB, JPG or PNG, pixel dimensions that fit the platform
- B) CMYK, 300 ppi, PDF/X
- C) CMYK, JPG, any size

Q5

Your printer wants 0.125 in of bleed. Photoshop has no bleed setting. How do you add it?

- A) Export As adds bleed automatically
- B) Move all your type to the edges
- C) Image ► Canvas Size to add it on every side, then extend the background into it

Q6

After scaling a layer down, its stroke and shadow look too heavy. What fixes it?

A) Rasterize the layer

B) Right-click the fx ► Scale Effects (or adjust the values by hand)

C) Convert the document to CMYK

◆ JOURNAL

You just finished your first designed piece. How does designing (type, shapes, layout) feel different from editing photos? Which did you enjoy more, and what does that tell you about where to go next? Also note: key concepts · what clicked · questions · ideas to try · your progress and feelings.

◆ NOTES

MODULE 5 SUMMARY

- ◆ **Hierarchy** is a planned reading order built with size, weight, and space. Leading, tracking, and kerning are your spacing controls.
- ◆ **Vector** is math and stays crisp; use it for everything that isn't a photo. A path can become a shape, a selection, or a mask.
- ◆ **Layer styles** are live effects; two is usually plenty. Copy and paste them for consistency.
- ◆ Export **RGB/JPG** for screen and **CMYK/PDF at 300 ppi** for print; keep the .psd master.

YOU FINISHED MODULE 5 AND THE PRACTITIONER TIER 🎉

You designed a poster from nothing: words, shapes, polish, and all. Five modules ago you were exporting your first fixed photo. You can now retouch, composite, and design. Next: Module 6, AI & Speed.

AI & Speed

Welcome to the Advanced tier. Today you add two superpowers: generative editing (add, remove, and expand a photo by describing it) and automation (record a task once, then run it on a whole folder). Follow along on your own computer and use the checklists so nothing gets skipped.

Lessons 17–19

3 lessons • Session 7

Name: _____

HOW TO USE THIS WORKBOOK

Each lesson has **By the end you can**, **Key ideas**, a **Worked example** (the steps from the lesson), a **Your turn** activity with space to write, a **Recipe card** to keep, a **Self-check** quiz, and a **Journal** prompt. Journal after every lesson: key concepts • what clicked • questions • ideas to try • your progress and feelings.

GENERATIVE FEATURES NEED THREE THINGS

Generative Fill (L17) and Generative Expand (L18) run in Adobe's cloud. You need **an internet connection**, to be **signed in to your Adobe account**, and **generative credits** (every Generate spends some). If they are not available today, your instructor will show you the same workflow with offline tools (the Remove tool, Content-Aware Fill, and Crop with Fill: Content-Aware Fill). The thinking is identical, so nothing you learn is wasted.

MODULE PROGRESS TRACKER

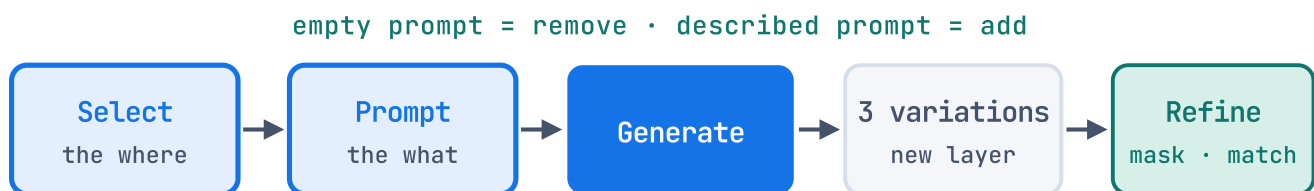
- ◆ ☐ **L17:** I removed a distraction and added a new element, each on its own generative layer
- ◆ ☐ **L18:** I uncropped and reframed a photo, and the horizon runs straight across the seam
- ◆ ☐ **L19:** I recorded an Action, batched a folder, and made a droplet
- ◆ ☐ **Homework:** I planned my capstone (L20) and built most of it (L21) before Session 8

◆ BY THE END YOU CAN

- ◆ **Remove** an object by selecting it and generating with an empty prompt
- ◆ **Add** new content by selecting an area and describing what belongs there
- ◆ Work with **generative layers** and cycle through **variations**
- ◆ Write prompts that work, and know Generative Fill's **limits**

◆ KEY IDEAS

- ◆ **Select, then describe.** The selection is the *where*; the prompt is the *what*.
- ◆ **Empty prompt = remove.** Photoshop fills the selection with plausible background (a smarter cousin of Content-Aware Fill from Module 1).
- ◆ **Described prompt = add.** Photoshop generates the object to fit the scene's light and perspective.
- ◆ Every result lands on a **new generative layer with its own mask**, with three variations to choose from. Your original pixels are never touched.
- ◆ The selection's **size and shape steer the result**: want something tall, make a tall selection.



Select the where, describe the what, generate, choose a variation, then finish with craft.

◆ WORKED EXAMPLE: REMOVE & ADD

- 1 Open a photo with a clear distraction and some open space. Save as `generative-working.psd`.
- 2 **Remove:** select the object loosely, with a little margin. In the **Contextual Task Bar** under the selection, click **Generative Fill**, leave the prompt empty, click **Generate**. Cycle the variations and pick the cleanest.
- 3 **Add:** select an empty area where something could believably go. Click Generative Fill, type a short, concrete prompt (`a small sailboat`), click Generate. Keep one variation, or Generate again for three more.

- 4 **Refine:** it is a normal layer with a mask, so mask a rough edge (Module 1), match light and color with clipped adjustments (Module 4), heal a small artifact (Module 3).

No task bar? Turn it on with Window ► Contextual Task Bar, or use Edit ► Generative Fill instead.

◆ YOUR TURN: REMOVE & ADD

Use your own photo or the practice file your instructor gives you. Tick each item as you finish it:

- ◆ ☐ A distraction is removed via an empty-prompt generation
- ◆ ☐ A new element is added via a described generation
- ◆ ☐ Each result sits on its own generative layer (original untouched)
- ◆ ☐ I cycled variations and picked the best
- ◆ ☐ I refined the result with masks or adjustments as needed

My prompt log. Write each prompt you tried and what happened (keep the ones that worked):

◆ WATCH OUT

- ◆ **Grayed out?** You probably need a current Photoshop, internet, and to be signed in. It uses generative credits.
- ◆ **Blurry or low-detail result?** The selection was very large. Generate in smaller pieces, or just regenerate; quality varies between runs.
- ◆ **Fine detail** (hands, text, small faces) can come out wrong. Zoom in and check.

◆ RECIPE CARD: GENERATIVE FILL

- 1 Select the area (loose, with margin), then click Generative Fill in the task bar
- 2 Remove: empty prompt → Generate
- 3 Add: short concrete prompt → Generate
- 4 Cycle the three variations; regenerate if needed
- 5 Refine on its generative layer (mask, match, heal)

Mantra: select the where, describe the what, then finish with craft.

A NOTE ON HONESTY

Generative edits can change what a photo *says*, not just how it looks. For journalism, evidence, or documentary work, adding or removing content crosses a line. Adobe embeds **Content Credentials** to flag AI edits. Use the power thoughtfully, and be transparent when it matters.

◆ SELF-CHECK

Q1

What is the basic Generative Fill workflow?

- A) Type a prompt first, and Photoshop decides where to put the result
- B) Select an area, then describe what should be there
- C) Paint over the area with a special generative brush

Q2

You want to remove a sign from the shoreline. After selecting it, what do you do?

- A) Press Delete and fill with white
- B) Type "sign" in the prompt and click Generate
- C) Leave the prompt empty and click Generate

Q3

Where does a Generative Fill result go?

- A) On a new generative layer with its own mask
- B) Merged into the Background layer
- C) Into a separate new document

Q4

Which prompt is most likely to work well?

A) "something nice to sit on"

B) "a wooden park bench"

C) "a stunning cinematic bench in dramatic golden light, ultra detailed, watercolor style"

Q5

You asked for a lighthouse, but every variation comes out short and squat. What should you change first?

A) Write a much longer prompt

B) Lower the generative layer's opacity

C) Make a taller selection

◆ JOURNAL

Generative Fill is powerful and a little unsettling. Where is your personal line between "cleaning up a photo" and "changing the truth of it"? Write it down; it is worth knowing before a client asks. Also note: key concepts · what clicked · questions · ideas to try · how you feel.

MINDSET

If your first generation looks odd, that is not failure, it is the first of three variations. Driving this tool well is a skill you build by trying, looking, and adjusting one or two words at a time.

◆ NOTES

◆ BY THE END YOU CAN

- ◆ Extend the canvas with the **Crop tool** and fill the new space generatively
- ◆ **Uncrop** a too-tight photo to give a subject room to breathe
- ◆ **Reframe** a photo to a new aspect ratio for print, web, or social
- ◆ Guide the fill with an optional prompt and keep the **seam** invisible

◆ KEY IDEAS

- ◆ **Expand is Generative Fill aimed at empty canvas** around your photo. Same generative layer, same variations, same optional prompt.
- ◆ The **Crop tool can crop outward**. Set **Fill: Generative Expand** in the options bar, drag the handles past the photo, then Generate.
- ◆ A **Ratio** only sets the shape. Photoshop first fits it inside the photo; you still drag outward.
- ◆ **Expand in bites**. Several small expansions look far better than one huge leap.
- ◆ **The horizon test**: a horizon or strong line that jumps at the seam is the fastest giveaway.

◆ WORKED EXAMPLE: UNCROP & REFRAME

- 1 Open a cramped photo. Save as `expand-working.psd`.
- 2 **Uncrop**: Crop tool (C), set **Fill: Generative Expand**. Drag a handle outward past the edge. Leave the task bar prompt empty and click **Generate**. (Pressing **Enter** or the checkmark may also generate straight away with no prompt, so use the task bar when you want to type one.)
- 3 **Reframe**: pick a Ratio (16:9 banner, 1:1 social, 4:5 feed post). Drag the handles outward until the box extends past the photo; the ratio stays locked. Generate.
- 4 **Guide it (optional)**: a short prompt steers the new area: `a calm beach`, `more forest`, `open sky`.
- 5 **Hide the seam**: zoom to 100% along the join. Anything repeating or misaligned? Select that strip and regenerate just it (L17). Then a tiny clipped Curves or a whisper of the Module 4 unifying grade over the whole frame.

◆ YOUR TURN: UNCROP & REFRAME

- ◆ ☐ The canvas was expanded past the original with Generative Expand
- ◆ ☐ The subject now has appropriate breathing room

- ◆ ☐ The photo reaches a useful new aspect ratio with no stretching
- ◆ ☐ Horizons and strong lines run continuously across the seam
- ◆ ☐ A subtle grade unifies original and generated areas

Which ratio did you choose, and where will this image be used? What did you see at 100% along the seam?

◆ WATCH OUT

- ◆ **Smeary or repetitive margins?** You expanded too far in one go. Undo, expand a smaller amount, generate, repeat. A short prompt can help too.
- ◆ **Horizon does not line up?** Cycle the variations; if none work, select a thin strip across the seam and regenerate it with Generative Fill.
- ◆ Expand for **composition and framing**, not to invent whole landscapes from a postage stamp. Quality drops the farther you get from real pixels.

◆ RECIPE CARD: GENERATIVE EXPAND

- 1 Crop tool (C), set Fill: Generative Expand
- 2 Optionally pick a target Ratio, then drag the handles outward past the photo
- 3 Empty prompt (continue) or a short prompt (steer) in the task bar → Generate
- 4 Expand in bites for big changes; pick the best variation
- 5 Check the seam at 100%; unify with a subtle grade

Mantra: crop outward, generate the margin, keep the horizon honest.

◆ SELF-CHECK

Q1

What is Generative Expand, really?

A) Generative Fill aimed at empty canvas around the photo

B) A filter that stretches the edge pixels outward

C) Image Size set to a larger number of pixels

Q2

You chose Ratio 16:9 and pressed Enter, and Photoshop cropped your photo smaller. What did you skip?

- A) Setting Fill to Background
- B) Using Free Transform first
- C) Dragging the crop handles outward past the photo

Q3

You need a much wider image, and one big expansion came out vague and repetitive. What is the better approach?

- A) Sharpen the generated area
- B) Expand in smaller steps, generating each time
- C) Lower the layer's opacity

Q4

What is the fastest giveaway of a bad expand?

- A) A slightly larger file size
- B) A horizon or strong line that jumps at the seam
- C) The generative layer's name

Q5

What does an empty prompt do in Generative Expand?

- A) Continues the existing scene into the new space
- B) Fills the new space with the background color
- C) Nothing; a prompt is required

◆ JOURNAL

Expand quietly changes an image's composition. When does giving a photo "room to breathe" improve it, and when does it dilute a shot that was strong because it was tight? Note one photo of yours that each rule applies

to. Also note: key concepts · what clicked · questions · ideas to try · how you feel.

MINDSET

The edges of a photo used to be a hard limit; now they are a suggestion. Use that freedom to compose *better*, not just bigger. If your seam shows, you have not failed, you have found the exact spot to fix next.

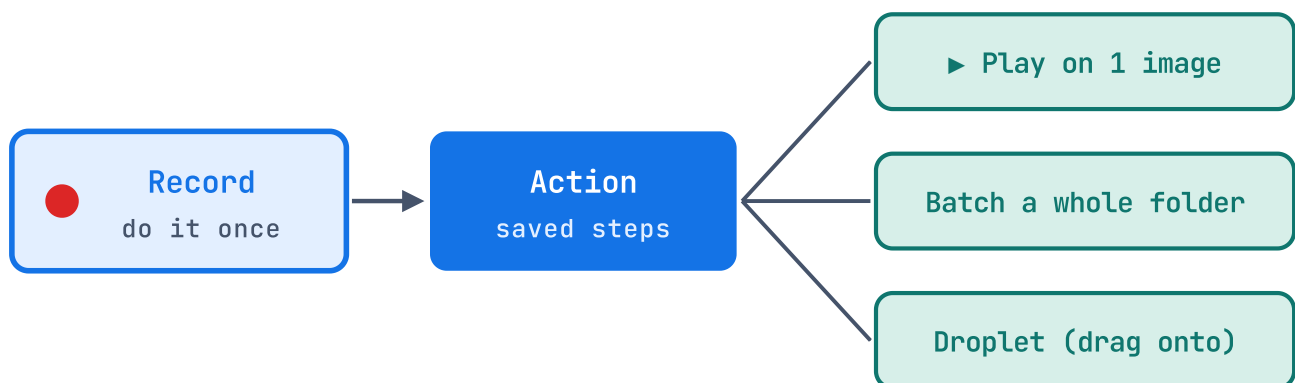
◆ NOTES

◆ BY THE END YOU CAN

- ◆ Record, play, and edit an Action
- ◆ Run an Action across a folder with **Batch**
- ◆ Resize and convert a whole shoot with the **Image Processor**
- ◆ Turn an Action into a drag-and-drop **droplet**

◆ KEY IDEAS

- ◆ An **Action** is a recording of your steps. Record once, replay forever: on one file, a folder, or as a droplet.
- ◆ Actions live in **Window ► Actions**, inside a **Set**. Red dot = record, square = stop, triangle = play.
- ◆ **Record general steps.** Fit Image fits the long edge for any orientation; Image Size would record a fixed width.
- ◆ **Automate the boring, keep the creative.** Resizing, converting, watermarking, and exporting are for Actions; grading and retouching are for you.
- ◆ Rule of thumb: if you do it more than twice, record it.



One recording, three ways to replay it.

◆ WORKED EXAMPLE: RECORD "WEB JPG 1200"

Put your test images in one folder and make an empty "processed" folder beside it.

- 1 Open one image. In the Actions panel, make a new Set (**Export Web**), then a new Action (**Web JPG 1200**), and click **Record** in the New Action dialog.
- 2 Edit ► **Convert to Profile**, destination **sRGB IEC61966-2.1**.
- 3 File ► Automate ► **Fit Image**, 1200 × 1200 px.

- 4 File ► **Place Embedded** your watermark and position it.
- 5 Layer ► **Flatten Image** (Save As only offers JPEG for a file without extra layers).
- 6 File ► **Save As** JPEG (quality 8 to 10 on the 0 to 12 scale) into the processed folder, then close the file.
- 7 Press **Stop**. Open a different image, select the Action, press **Play** to test.
- 8 File ► Automate ► **Batch**: choose the Set and Action, Source = input folder, Destination = processed folder, tick **Override Action "Save As" Commands**. Click OK.

◆ YOUR TURN: RECORD & BATCH

- ◆ ☐ An Action is recorded with clear, general steps
- ◆ ☐ It plays correctly on a single test file
- ◆ ☐ Batch processed an entire folder into the destination
- ◆ ☐ Outputs are consistent (size, color, watermark)
- ◆ ☐ Originals are untouched (batch wrote copies)
- ◆ ☐ I made a droplet (File ► Automate ► Create Droplet) and dragged a folder onto it

Write the steps your Actions panel shows, in order. Did anything misbehave on the test file? What did you fix?

◆ THREE AUTOMATION TOOLS: WHICH ONE WHEN?

TOOL	WHERE	BEST FOR
Image Processor	File ► Scripts	Quick "make web copies of this shoot" jobs (JPG, PSD, or TIFF), no recording needed
Batch	File ► Automate	Anything your Action can do, across a folder, with full control of source and destination
Droplet	File ► Automate ► Create Droplet	An Action saved as a little app on your desktop: drag files onto it (Photoshop must be installed; the droplet launches it)

◆ WATCH OUT

- ◆ **Batch broke on some files?** Usually the Action recorded something too specific, or hit an unexpected file type or color mode. Re-record with general steps, and in Batch enable **Suppress color profile warnings**

and error logging to a file.

- ◆ **Generative steps in an Action** vary per run and need the cloud, so they are less predictable in a batch. Test carefully.

◆ RECIPE CARD: AUTOMATE

- 1 Actions panel: new Set → new Action → Record
- 2 Do the task once (convert, Fit Image, watermark, flatten, save), then Stop
- 3 Test Play on one file; edit steps if needed
- 4 File ► Automate ► Batch across a folder (set Source + Destination; tick Override Action "Save As" Commands)
- 5 For handoff, Create Droplet; for quick resizes, Image Processor

Mantra: if you do it more than twice, record it.

◆ SELF-CHECK

Q1

What is an Action?

- A) A JavaScript program you write in a code editor
- B) A recording of steps you can replay with one click
- C) A saved setting for a single tool

Q2

Why record File ► Automate ► Fit Image instead of Image ► Image Size?

- A) Fit Image produces sharper results
- B) Image Size cannot be recorded
- C) Fit Image fits the long edge on landscape and portrait files alike

Q3

Your batch ran, but every file was saved into the folder you used while recording instead of your Destination. What was missed?

A) Ticking Override Action "Save As" Commands

B) Ticking Suppress color profile warnings

C) Choosing a different Set

Q4

While recording, Save As does not offer JPEG. Which step belongs before it?

A) Edit ► Convert to Profile

B) File ► Automate ► Fit Image

C) Layer ► Flatten Image

Q5

You just need sRGB web JPGs of a whole shoot, with no recording. Which tool?

A) Batch

B) Image Processor

C) Create Droplet

Q6

What is a droplet?

A) An Action saved as a drag-and-drop app

B) A watermark file

C) A layer style that adds a water effect

◆ JOURNAL

List three repetitive tasks in your own workflow that an Action could eat. Which one, automated, would save you the most time this month? Also note: key concepts · what clicked · questions · ideas to try · how you feel.

MINDSET

An Action that breaks on the first try is normal: it is just telling you which step was too specific. Delete that step, re-record it, and test again. Debugging your own automation is a professional skill.

◆ NOTES

BEFORE SESSION 8: CAPSTONE HOMEWORK

PLAN ON BUILDING AT HOME

Session 8 is not long enough to build a capstone from scratch. Arrive with your piece about **70 to 80% done**: the studio time is for finishing, fixing, and getting help, and the second half of the session is presentations and critique.

◆ PART 1: PLAN IT (READ LESSON 20)

- ◆ ☐ I picked one brief: poster · surreal composite · retouched portrait · old photo restoration · product hero shot · brand mini-kit
- ◆ ☐ I wrote my one-line brief: "A [what] for [who], to be seen [where], that feels [three adjectives]."
- ◆ ☐ I collected 5 to 10 reference images
- ◆ ☐ I made a rough moodboard: 3 to 5 colors, one or two fonts, a thumbnail layout
- ◆ ☐ I wrote my skill map and set up my document (size, resolution, color mode)
- ◆ ☐ The photos and assets my piece needs are on my laptop (my own, or free-license images whose license I checked)

My one-line brief:

◆ PART 2: BUILD MOST OF IT (READ LESSON 21)

- ◆ ☐ Composition blocked in, then refined big to small
- ◆ ☐ Layers named, grouped, and color-labeled as I went
- ◆ ☐ Snapshots before risky steps; versioned saves (`capstone_v1.psd` , `_v2` ...)
- ◆ ☐ I wrote down the one or two things I most want help with in Session 8

YOU FINISHED MODULE 6 🎉

You can add, remove, and expand by describing, and you can make a hundred files consistent with one click. You have now met every major capability in the course. Session 8 is the Capstone: no new tools, just you, a plan, and everything you know.

Capstone

No new tools, only you and everything you have learned. This module is one self-directed project, taken from idea to presented portfolio piece: plan it, build it well, then present it and ship it.

Lessons 20-22

3 lessons • Session 8

Name: _____

MOST OF THE CAPSTONE HAPPENS AT HOME

Session 8 is three hours, and half of it is presentations. **Plan (L20) and build most of your piece (L21) before Session 8**, and arrive about **70 to 80% done**. In class, the studio block is for finishing, fixing, and getting help.

HOW TO USE THIS WORKBOOK

L20 is a planning worksheet: fill it in before you open Photoshop. L21 is your studio log. L22 holds your artist statement, your self-critique, and the feedback you receive. Each lesson also has a Self-check and a Journal prompt: key concepts • what clicked • questions • ideas to try • your progress and feelings.

CAPSTONE TRACKER

- ◆ ☐ **L20** (home): one-line brief, references, moodboard, skill map, document set up
- ◆ ☐ **L21** (home): piece built about 70 to 80%, in a named, grouped, versioned file
- ◆ ☐ **Session 8**: finished, exported, statement written
- ◆ ☐ **L22**: presented, critiqued, and shipped to a portfolio or a wall

◆ BY THE END YOU CAN

- ◆ Choose a brief that plays to your strengths and interests
- ◆ Define the goal, audience, and constraints **before** touching Photoshop
- ◆ Gather references and build a quick moodboard
- ◆ Map the skills and layer strategy your piece will need

◆ KEY IDEAS

- ◆ **Brief before brush.** Answer three questions on paper first: **What is it for? Who is it for? What does "done" look like?**
- ◆ The **destination** (print, web, social) sets size, resolution, and color mode.
- ◆ A **moodboard** (palette, fonts, layout) makes most creative decisions before the blank canvas can pressure you.
- ◆ A **skill map** turns a vague idea into a concrete build checklist.
- ◆ **Ambition, calibrated:** stretch one notch, not ten. A finished piece at 80% of your dream beats an abandoned masterpiece.

◆ PICK YOUR BRIEF

BRIEF	LEANS ON	GREAT IF YOU LIKED...
☐ Movie / event poster	Compositing + type + layer styles	Modules 4 and 5
☐ Surreal photo composite	Selections, masks, match light, shadows	Module 4
☐ Portrait, fully retouched	Frequency separation, dodge & burn, grade	Modules 2 and 3
☐ Old photo restoration	Healing, cloning, tone, color	Modules 1, 2, and 3
☐ Product hero shot	Cutout, background, light, generative	Modules 4 and 6
☐ Brand mini-kit (logo lockup + social set)	Shapes, type, Smart Objects, batch	Modules 5 and 6

◆ STEP 1: WRITE THE ONE-LINE BRIEF (5 MIN)

"A [what] for [who], to be seen [where], that feels [three adjectives]."

Example: "A gig poster for a local band, to be seen printed on a wall, that feels loud, retro, and warm."

What does "done" look like for this piece? (How will you know when to stop?)

◆ STEP 2: GATHER REFERENCES (10 MIN)

Collect 5 to 10 images that capture the feeling you want: color, composition, mood, type. Screenshot them into one board. You are gathering feeling and direction, not things to copy. What do you like about each?

◆ STEP 3: BUILD A QUICK MOODBOARD (10 MIN)

Palette (3 to 5 colors, with hex codes if you have them):

Layout thumbnail: where do the focal point, title, and supporting info sit? A scribble is enough.

Fonts (one or two, Module 5's rule):

◆ STEP 4: MAP THE SKILLS (5 MIN)

List the moves your piece needs, tagged by module, for example: "cut out subject (M4), match light (M4), type hierarchy (M5), grade (M2)." This is your build checklist for L21. Circle any skill that feels shaky, and do a five-minute warm-up on it first.

◆ SET UP THE DOCUMENT

Start from the New Document preset tab that matches your destination. **Print:** real-world size at 300 ppi (convert to CMYK for the printer at export, Module 5). **Web / Mobile / social:** the platform's pixel size, RGB. Width _____ Height _____ Resolution _____ Color mode _____ File name _____

◆ RECIPE CARD: PLAN A PIECE

- 1 One-line brief: a [what] for [who], seen [where], feeling [3 adjectives]
- 2 Gather 5 to 10 references
- 3 Moodboard: palette + one or two fonts + layout sketch
- 4 Skill map: list the moves, tagged by module
- 5 New Document at the right size / resolution / color mode

Mantra: brief before brush. **Plan complete** when you can describe the finished piece in one sentence, you have a palette and layout, and you know which skills you will use.

◆ SELF - CHECK

Q1

Which three questions should you answer before opening Photoshop?

A) What is it for? Who is it for? What does "done" look like?

B) Which filter? Which font? Which brush?

C) How many layers? How many hours? How many colors?

Q2

Which of these is a complete one-line brief?

A) "Something cool with my vacation photos."

B) "A gig poster for a local band, to be seen printed on a wall, that feels loud, retro, and warm."

C) "A poster, 18 × 24 in, 300 ppi."

Q3

What belongs on a quick moodboard?

- A) A palette of 3 to 5 colors, one or two fonts, and a rough layout sketch
- B) The finished artwork
- C) A list of every Photoshop tool you know

Q4

Your piece is a poster to be printed. How do you set up the document?

- A) A Web preset at screen size, 72 ppi
- B) The Print preset at real-world size, 300 ppi, converting to CMYK for the printer at export
- C) Any size for now; fix it at the end

Q5

How ambitious should your capstone be?

- A) The most epic idea you can imagine
- B) One notch beyond what you have done, not ten
- C) Exactly something you have already made before

◆ JOURNAL

Reread your very first journal entry from Module 0, the one about what you hoped to create. Does the brief you just chose connect to it? It is fine if you have grown in a new direction; notice either way. Also note: key concepts · what clicked · questions · ideas to try · how you feel.

MINDSET

Choosing a brief can feel scarier than any tool, because now it is your vision on the line. That nervous excitement is the feeling of doing real creative work. Preparation is the part of "talent" you can simply choose to have.

◆ BY THE END YOU CAN

- ◆ Build in the right order: **block in big, refine small**
- ◆ Keep a complex file organized with **named, grouped, color-labeled** layers
- ◆ Protect your work with **snapshots** and **versioned saves**
- ◆ Use a habit of **stepping back** to judge the whole piece

◆ KEY IDEAS

- ◆ **A tidy file is a fast file.** Name layers the moment they matter ("sky," "model-cutout," "title"), group by role (BACKGROUND, SUBJECT, TYPE, GRADE), and color-label the groups.
- ◆ **Build big to small.** Block in the whole composition roughly; refine only once the layout works.
- ◆ **Snapshot before risky moves.** Window ► History, camera icon (Create New Snapshot); **Alt/⌘**-click it to name the snapshot. History clears when you close the file, snapshots included, so also save versions: `capstone_v1.psd`, `_v2` ...
- ◆ **Step back on purpose:** zoom to fit, squint, and View ► Flip Horizontal (it flips only the view; choose it again to flip back).

◆ WORKED EXAMPLE: THE STUDIO SESSION

- 1 **Block in:** place background, subject, and space for type roughly. Select related layers, **Ctrl/⌘ + G** to group, double-click the group name to rename it. Right-click a group's eye icon to pick a color label. Judge the layout.
- 2 **Refine, module by module:** cut out and mask (M1, M4), match light and color (M4), retouch (M3), grade (M2), set type (M5), add styles (M5), generative touches (M6). Stay non-destructive: adjustment layers, Smart Objects, masks. Snapshot before each risky step.
- 3 **Step back, throughout:** does it still serve the brief? Is the focal point winning?
- 4 **Finish and clean up:** the unifying grade over everything (M2, M4); a 100% pass for stray artifacts; every group named and labeled, dead layers deleted; save a clean `capstone_final.psd` master.

◆ YOUR TURN: STUDIO LOG

Log each build session (date, what you did, the snapshot or version you saved, what is next):

My goal for the Session 8 studio block (the one or two things I will finish, and what I need help with):

- ◆ ☐ The piece matches the brief from L20
- ◆ ☐ Built non-destructively (adjustment layers, Smart Objects, masks)
- ◆ ☐ Layers are named, grouped, and color-labeled
- ◆ ☐ Snapshots and versioned saves protected the risky steps
- ◆ ☐ A clean layered master is saved

◆ WATCH OUT

- ◆ "I'll tidy up later" becomes forty mystery layers. Naming in the moment costs seconds; retrofitting costs an hour.
- ◆ **File huge and slow?** Save a full layered version first, then merge or flatten finished sections in a working copy. Edit ► Purge if history is eating memory.
- ◆ **Feels worse than before?** Normal: it is the middle. Jump to an earlier snapshot or version, step back, and reread the brief.

◆ STRONG-PIECE RUBRIC (GRADE YOURSELF BEFORE CALLING IT DONE)

QUALITY	YES / NOT YET
A clear focal point	☐ yes ☐ not yet
Consistent light and color	☐ yes ☐ not yet
Clean edges and masks	☐ yes ☐ not yet
Deliberate type (if any)	☐ yes ☐ not yet ☐ n/a
No distracting artifacts	☐ yes ☐ not yet

◆ RECIPE CARD: WORK CLEAN

- 1 Block in the composition before refining
- 2 Name layers and group by role immediately; color-label groups
- 3 Stay non-destructive: adjustment layers, Smart Objects, masks

- 4 Snapshot before risky steps; save versioned .psd files
- 5 Step back often: squint, flip, fit view, re-check the brief

Mantra: a tidy file is a fast file.

◆ SELF - CHECK

Q1

What is the right build order for a big piece?

- A) Perfect the small details first, then arrange the layout
- B) Block in the composition roughly, then refine big to small
- C) Always set the type first, then everything else

Q2

How do you give a layer group a color label?

- A) Right-click the group's eye (visibility) icon and pick a color
- B) Choose Layer ► Rename Group
- C) Double-click the group's thumbnail

Q3

Which statement about History snapshots is true?

- A) Snapshots are saved inside the .psd and are there next week
- B) History clears when you close the file, snapshots included, so you should also save versioned files
- C) Taking snapshots means you never need to save

Q4

What does View ► Flip Horizontal do?

- A) Mirrors the image's pixels, so you must undo it before saving
- B) Flips only the view, so you see the piece with fresh eyes
- C) Mirrors only the selected layer

Q5

Your capstone file is huge and slow. What is the safe first move?

A) Save a full layered version, then merge or flatten finished sections in a working copy

B) Flatten the master file

C) Convert every group to a Smart Object, which always shrinks the file

◆ JOURNAL

Which skill did your capstone lean on most, and which did you reach for and realize you needed to practice more? That gap is your next lesson, and knowing it is a sign of real growth. Also note: key concepts · what clicked · questions · ideas to try · how you feel.

MINDSET

A dip mid-project is not failure; it is the middle. Finishing a self-directed piece is a different kind of hard than following steps, and you are doing it. Save a version, make the brave edit, and know you can always get back.

◆ BY THE END YOU CAN

- ◆ **Export** your piece correctly for its destination
- ◆ **Present** it in context with mockups so it reads as finished work
- ◆ Write a short **artist statement** and **critique** your piece with a rubric
- ◆ Build a **portfolio entry** and know where to grow next

◆ KEY IDEAS

- ◆ **Present, critique, ship.** Finishing the pixels is not the finish line.
- ◆ **Keep the layered .psd master.** Export a delivery copy: JPG or PNG in sRGB for screen, or a print PDF at 300 ppi, in CMYK, with bleed, to the printer's spec (Module 5).
- ◆ **Mockups** are layered PSDs built around a Smart Object. Context tells the viewer how to read the work.
- ◆ **Done is a decision.** The rubric helps you make that call instead of fiddling forever.

◆ WORKED EXAMPLE: PLACE YOUR ART IN A MOCKUP

- 1 Open a mockup PSD (Adobe Stock and many design sites offer them; check the license).
- 2 Double-click the **Smart Object layer's thumbnail**. Its contents open in their own tab (a `.psb` file).
- 3 Place or paste your art there and scale it to fill. Save (Ctrl/⌘ + S) and close that tab.
- 4 Back in the mockup, your art appears warped to fit the scene. Add a soft shadow and a believable setting.

No mockup file? Use the plain wall scene your instructor provides: File ► Place Embedded your export (it arrives as a Smart Object), scale it into the frame's opening, and add a soft Drop Shadow layer style (Module 5) so it sits in the frame instead of floating on it.

◆ YOUR TURN: SHIP CHECKLIST

- ◆ ☐ Delivery file exported correctly for its destination
- ◆ ☐ Presented in at least one context mockup with a shadow
- ◆ ☐ A before/after or process shot accompanies it
- ◆ ☐ A two-sentence artist statement written
- ◆ ☐ The layered master is saved and safe

My two-sentence statement. Sentence one: what it is and who it is for. Sentence two: one interesting decision you made and why.

Example: "A gig poster for a local retro band. I graded it warm and added film grain so it feels like a memory of a summer night."

◆ THE HONEST CRITIQUE

Score yourself first. Then, during presentations, write down what your reviewers said.

ASK	LOOKING FOR	ME
Focal point	Does one thing clearly win my attention first?	☐ ☐
Light & color	Consistent across the whole image? Any element that does not belong?	☐ ☐
Edges & masks	Any fringe, halo, or chopped hair at 100%?	☐ ☐
Type (if any)	Clear hierarchy, tasteful spacing, one or two fonts?	☐ ☐
Believability	Do shadows agree on one light? Any telltale AI artifacts?	☐ ☐
The squint test	Blurred down, does the composition still read?	☐ ☐

Me: first box = strong, second box = not yet.

Feedback I received (the first thing people noticed · the glows · the grows):

When I review a classmate: open with "The first thing I notice is... and what confused me was...", then pick one rubric row and give one **glow** (what works, specifically) and one **grow** ("I wonder if..."). Critique the work, not the person.

◆ WHERE TO GO NEXT

PATH	DOUBLE DOWN ON
☐ Photo retoucher	Modules 2 & 3: color, frequency separation, dodge & burn
☐ Compositor / matte artist	Modules 1 & 4: selections, masks, light matching
☐ Graphic / poster designer	Module 5: type, layout, layer styles (and pair with Illustrator)

☐ Speed & production

Module 6: generative workflows, Actions, batch pipelines

Keep the **Recipes** library open for "how do I do X again?" You do not need to memorize everything.

◆ SELF-CHECK

Q1

Your piece will be shown on screens. What do you deliver?

- A) The layered .psd, so people can see your work
- B) A JPG or PNG in sRGB, keeping the layered .psd master safe
- C) A CMYK PDF with bleed

Q2

How do you put your art into a mockup template?

- A) Double-click the Smart Object layer's thumbnail, place your art in the .psb tab, save, and close it
- B) Paste your art on top of the mockup and Free Transform it until it roughly fits
- C) Flatten the mockup, then paint your art onto it

Q3

What goes in the two-sentence artist statement?

- A) A list of every tool you used
- B) What it is and who it is for, then one interesting decision you made and why
- C) An explanation of what you did not have time to finish

Q4

The rubric's "Believability" row asks...

- A) Do shadows agree on one light? Any telltale AI artifacts?
- B) Are there only one or two fonts?
- C) Is the file under 10 MB?

Q5

"Done is a decision" means...

- A) Keep polishing until the piece is perfect
- B) Use the rubric to decide the piece is finished, then ship it
- C) Wait until someone else tells you it is done

◆ FINAL JOURNAL

Your final entry is a big one: key concepts from the whole course that stuck · the technique you are proudest of learning · what still feels shaky and is worth practicing · what you want to make next.

The final prompt: go back and read your very first journal entry from Module 0, the one where you wrote why you wanted to learn Photoshop and what you hoped to create. Answer it now, from the other side. Did you build toward it? How does the person who wrote that entry compare to you today?

THE ONE IDEA TO KEEP

If the tools fade from memory, keep this: **work non-destructively, and decide what the viewer should see first.** Skill is just reps plus reflection, and you already know how to do both.

◆ NOTES

YOU FINISHED THE COURSE 🎉

You started by fixing and exporting one photo. Now you can work non-destructively, make clean selections, grade light and color, retouch naturally, composite believably, design with type, use generative tools and automation, and plan, build, and present a portfolio piece. The blank canvas used to be intimidating. Now it is an invitation. Congratulations, and welcome to the craft.

Photoshop: From First Win to Finished Work · Participant Workbook

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